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WHAT RON DESANTIS MEANS FOR AMERICA

by
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The DeSantis Project

Molly Ball is the national political correspondent at TIME, based in the Washington, D.C. bureau. She covers campaigns, the White House, political personalities and policy debates across America. She has received numerous awards for her political coverage, including the Dirksen Award for Distinguished Reporting of Congress, the Gerald R. Ford Prize for Distinguished Reporting on the Presidency and the Toner Prize for Excellence in Political Reporting. She is the author of Pelosi, a bestselling biography of the first woman Speaker of the House.

It’s a Tuesday morning in Tallahassee, and a wood-paneled hearing room at the Florida legislature is packed. The state senate’s fiscal-policy committee is considering a bill to prohibit most abortions after six weeks of pregnancy, and dozens of citizens have lined up to testify: anguished young students in colorful hair and “abortion is health care” T-shirts; little old ladies wearing cardigans and crosses. For hours they speak in emotional terms as the senators listen.

Yet an air of inevitability hangs over the proceedings. Governor Ron DeSantis supports this bill, and therefore it is destined to pass. In Tallahassee these days, what the governor wants, the governor gets. It is DeSantis who welcomed this fight, DeSantis who calls the shots, and DeSantis who will reap the credit—or blame—for his latest move in a frenzy of right-wing policymaking.

His dominance is hard to overstate. From school-board meetings to the Walt Disney Corp., the shelves of elementary-school libraries to local mask ordinances, everything bears his stamp. Having shepherded his state through the COVID-19 pandemic, bucking the political and medical establishments to follow his own read of the data, DeSantis has manipulated levers of power to enact a sweeping agenda. The week I landed in Tallahassee, he signed an expansive school-voucher law and a measure investing more than $700 million in affordable housing. The legislature was hearing his proposed ban on gender-affirming health care for minors, a bill to expand gun rights that would allow concealed carrying of firearms without a permit, another that would dramatically curtail union rights, and a bid to prohibit socially conscious investing. All would eventually pass. At DeSantis' behest, legislators this year also eliminated diversity programs at public universities, made it easier to sentence criminals to death, and barred schools from using trans students' preferred pronouns.

For a typical Republican governor, any of these policies might represent a signature achievement. For DeSantis, they're the latest line items in an agenda he calls the Florida Blueprint. "We've had conservative leadership in Florida for the past 23 years, but we've passed more conservative bills in the past two years than the previous 20, and more this year than the past 22," says GOP state senator Joe Gruters. "It's a rocket ship, a steam engine."

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Out of a combination of fear and mutual interest, legislators have put aside their own pet projects to do DeSantis' bidding, passing bills to shield his travel records from the public and allow him to run for President without resigning the governorship. They've also been enlisted to clean up his messes, retroactively legalizing his migrant flights to Martha's Vineyard last year and attempting to restore state control of the special tax district around Disney World amid the company's feud with DeSantis over LGBT rights. "This governor has used all of his powers to make sure everyone around him is in lockstep," says Jeff Brandes, a libertarian-leaning former GOP state senator who lost a seat on a prized committee after clashing with DeSantis over fiscal issues.

By operationalizing the culture war into a set of concrete policies, DeSantis has transformed the nation's third most populous state. What was once the butt of jokes about gators and retirees is now the swaggering, Southern-tinged Free State of Florida—where men are men, woke is broke, and business is booming; 1,200 net new residents arrive every day. "It's in the air, it's everywhere, it's amazing," says former GOP Representative David Jolly, no fan of the vibe shift. "It's between neighbors, it's when you go to restaurants, when you go to schools. You're on one side or the other, and people know it." A Florida native, Jolly is considering moving his family out of the state.

If critics see DeSantis as a would-be authoritarian, allies see a conservative who gets things done. Many predicted that his hard-charging first term in office would provoke a backlash. Instead the opposite occurred. While Republicans across the country struggled last November, DeSantis romped to a 19-point re-election victory, the biggest win for a Florida governor in decades. What was once America's paradigmatic swing state now pulsates bright red. For the first time in modern history, registered Republicans outnumber Democrats. The people of Florida seem to like the steady hand—even if it's an iron fist.

To fans, DeSantis' success proves that a pugilistic, big-government conservatism that promises ruthless competence instead of Trumpian chaos can win broad support, including a growing share of working-class and minority voters. "We've shown that you don't have to do it the liberal way, and we're the envy of the nation when you look at our results," says state representative Randy Fine, a Republican who has sponsored some of DeSantis' most controversial legislation and may soon be rewarded with an appointment as a university president despite no background in academia. "DeSantis says what he's going to do and he does it. People like that, even if they don't agree with him."

The Blueprint has already done more than just make DeSantis the darling of right-wing media and donors. It has changed the face of

American politics. His gerrymandering of the state's political map added enough red seats to secure the U.S. House of Representatives for the GOP last November. Fellow governors, invited by DeSantis to policy summits where they study his approach, have enacted laws modeled on his policies, affecting millions of lives beyond Florida. And his agenda has set the stakes for the 2024 presidential primary. Donald Trump's campaign has been notably more focused on transgender issues, education, and "wokeness" than on the tax cuts and vaccine development that might be considered his main presidential accomplishments.

Soon DeSantis is expected to announce his presidential run and become Trump's chief rival for the Republican nomination. Trump has attacked him relentlessly, denting DeSantis' standing with GOP voters and sowing doubts about his national viability. But those who have witnessed DeSantis operate say it would be foolish to count him out. "He's not charming," says GOP state representative Fiona McFarland. "But he's a terminator."

DeSantis' methods of keeping the legislature in line are not subtle. At one point, a Republican lawmaker was planning to oppose a DeSantis-backed bill until he got a phone call from the governor, who had helped the lawmaker get elected. Without preliminaries, DeSantis barked into the phone, "Do you know why you're here?"

"Yes," the startled lawmaker answered. Without saying another word, the governor hung up, two people familiar with the incident told me. Message delivered.

Unlike his predecessors, DeSantis does not roam the halls of the Florida statehouse and spends little time in his office in the legislative building. The office, situated on the ground level, has become code for DeSantis, Politico recently reported. "That's Plaza's bill," lawmakers will say.

DeSantis, 44, was born in Jacksonville and raised in the Gulf Coast city of Dunedin, where his mother was a nurse and his father installed Nielsen TV-rating boxes. A book-smart introvert and talented baseball player, he graduated with honors from Yale University (where I knew him slightly) and Harvard Law School before joining the Navy. As a member of the Judge Advocate General (JAG) Corps, he was stationed at Guantánamo Bay and then deployed to Iraq, where he served as a legal adviser to the SEALs during the 2007 troop surge.

In 2010, DeSantis left active duty and settled near Jacksonville, where he worked as a lawyer and married a local TV anchor, Casey Black, whom he met at a driving range. As the Tea Party fervor crested, he self-published a book of conservative ideas, *Dreams From Our Founding Fathers*, and traveled to local activist meetings to give talks and sell it. DeSantis was looking for a way into elected office but unsure where to start until he met two Florida consultants, Tim Baker and Brian Hughes, who had made a specialty of electing conservative insurgent veterans. DeSantis thought he might run for state legislature or some other low-level office. The consultants persuaded him he had a shot at a Jacksonville-area congressional district that had just been redrawn to favor the GOP.

The 2012 primary was crowded, and DeSantis had little money or name recognition. The consultants devised a guerrilla strategy designed to tap into the new conservative zeitgeist. Casey, a local celebrity, began using her married name on television. The couple went door to door, using his advisers' data to target households with the strongest record of voting in Republican primaries. Meanwhile, his consultants, who had agreed to backload their fees, gambled by spending nearly all of the campaign's meager budget on an ad on Fox News.

DeSantis began to close the gap on his more experienced rivals. He impressed national right-wing groups and won the endorsement of the influential Club for Growth, which brought a flood of cash from donors. He won the seven-way GOP primary by a wide margin, drawing nearly 40% of the vote.

Buoyed by this success, the consultants drew up a plan to raise DeSantis' profile as he headed to Washington. But the candidate dismissed them: he didn't want to spend more money with his election to Congress all but assured. It was only when Baker and Hughes expressed concern that the dispute might become public that DeSantis relented, according to two people familiar with the episode. Their role in his early career is not mentioned in DeSantis' new memoir, *The Courage to Be Free*, which describes the door-knocking strategy as if it were DeSantis' own idea. "He has a habit of rewriting history," one of the people familiar with the episode told me. "There's Richard Petty, there's Tom Petty, and then there's Ron DeSantis petty."

DeSantisland

The governor has manipulated the levers of power to pass a sweeping right-wing agenda

ABORTION

In April, DeSantis signed a bill that would ban most abortions after six weeks of pregnancy, building on a previous 15-week ban he signed into law that predated the Supreme Court's decision striking down *Roe v. Wade*

EDUCATION

School vouchers are now available to all Floridians regardless of income, while the teaching of gender and sexual topics is banned from kindergarten through 12th grade in public schools, an expansion of last year's "parental rights in education" law

TRANSGENDER RESTRICTIONS

DeSantis-backed laws have barred trans athletes from women's public-school sports, prohibited gender-affirming treatments for minors, and blocked trans people from using their preferred bathrooms in public buildings

IMMIGRATION

A new law restricts undocumented immigrants' access to social services and makes it harder for businesses to hire them. DeSantis has also spent more than $1.5 million flying migrants to Martha's Vineyard

CRIMINAL JUSTICE

DeSantis-backed measures permit nonunanimous death-penalty verdicts and allow child molesters to be sentenced to death. A bill cracking down on violent protests was blocked by the courts

FIGHTING "WOKENESS"

A sweeping ban on schools teaching critical race theory was stopped in court, but educators say it has had a chilling effect nonetheless. DeSantis has also prohibited diversity initiatives at public colleges

Over three terms in the House, DeSantis was a reliable conservative not known for his people skills. Congressional colleagues describe him as strikingly aloof, rebuffing or ignoring friendly overtures and wearing earbuds to avoid conversation. A co-founder of the right-wing Freedom Caucus, DeSantis in his memoir describes his years in Congress as mostly frustrating. GOP leaders exercised top-down power, he argues, but weren't willing to fully use their leverage to achieve conservative goals. He does, however, tout his work on the Puppies Assisting Wounded Servicemembers (PAWS) Act, which funded a program providing service dogs to veterans with PTSD.

In 2016, DeSantis briefly ran for the U.S. Senate seat that Marco Rubio had vacated to run for President, but dropped out when Rubio decided to return to the Senate. Instead, DeSantis announced a run for governor in 2018. It was another insurgent campaign: the Florida GOP establishment already had its handpicked candidate, Adam Putnam, the state agriculture commissioner. But DeSantis again read the changing currents of the GOP. He appeared relentlessly on Fox, emerging as a reliable defender of Trump, particularly on the Russia scandal that enveloped the first years of the President's term.

On Dec. 8, 2017, DeSantis and a fellow right-wing Florida Congressman, Matt Gaetz, hitched a ride on Air Force One to a Trump rally in Pensacola. Along the way, Gaetz urged the President to endorse DeSantis for governor. He described Putnam as a Never Trumper and read aloud a list of negative things Putnam had said about the President. A couple of weeks later, after catching another DeSantis appearance on Fox, Trump endorsed him on Twitter. DeSantis made the most of it, mentioning Trump 21 times in his first debate with Putnam and running an ad that jokingly showed him reading *The Art of the Deal* to his young children and "building the wall" with toy blocks.

In the general election, DeSantis faced Andrew Gillum, the progressive Black mayor of Tallahassee. In an early post-primary appearance, DeSantis said, “The last thing we need to do is to monkey this up by trying to embrace a socialist agenda.” Democrats decried his verbiage as a racist dog whistle. DeSantis refused to back down or apologize. But while many national observers remember that controversy, in Florida the campaign mostly focused on state issues. “What Ron said to me in 2018 when we were laying out the strategy was, ‘We’re going to nationalize the primary and localize the general,’” Gaetz tells me. “The plan was to run against Putnam on national issues and then paint Gillum as in the pocket of Big Sugar.” In a good year for Democrats, DeSantis defeated Gillum by less than half a percentage point.

Trump has claimed credit for DeSantis’ rise, but one former DeSantis adviser says the governor sees his success as foreordained. “He has a providential belief that he will talk sincerely about. He believes he is exactly where God planned him to be at all times,” the adviser says. “I’m sure he believes, ‘It was nice of Trump to help me kick the sh-t out of Adam Putnam. But it would have happened anyway.’”

The Florida governorship has not always been a powerful position. Until 1968, the governor could serve only one term, and until the 1990s he (Florida has only had male governors) shared decisionmaking powers with six other statewide elected officials. Reforms that took effect during Jeb Bush's tenure in the early 2000s shrank the elected cabinet to just three members while also giving the executive more say in judicial nominations. At the same time, term limits approved by voters in a 1992 ballot initiative took hold, turning the legislature into a revolving door where lawmakers could no longer amass power over decades. As DeSantis entered office in 2019, the power of Florida's executive was already at a historic high.

He was determined to use every bit of it. "One of my first orders of business after getting elected was to have my transition team amass an exhaustive list of all the constitutional, statutory, and customary powers of the governor," he writes in *The Courage to Be Free*. "I wanted to be sure that I was using every lever available to advance our priorities." Aides from the time have corroborated this account, describing a thick binder of information that DeSantis proceeded to devour.

Conscious of his narrow victory, DeSantis initially sought to broaden his appeal. "We got elected by the hair of our chinny-chin-chin, so the goal of the transition was to grow the universe of DeSantis supporters in the state of Florida and do better with nonwhite voters, independents, suburban women, and young people," says Gaetz, who chaired the transition to the governorship. (Once an ally of both men, Gaetz has grown distant with DeSantis since endorsing Trump's 2024 campaign.) DeSantis approved the sale of smokable medical marijuana, appointed Democrats to prominent posts in the administration, raised teacher pay, and proposed record levels of environmental funding for the Everglades. He posthumously exonerated the Groveland Four, Black men wrongly accused of raping a white woman in 1949.

When his proclamation honoring the third anniversary of the massacre at the Pulse nightclub in Orlando was criticized for failing to mention the affected groups, DeSantis' office reissued it with a new sentence decrying "hatred towards the LGBTQ and Hispanic communities."

Even early on, though, there were hints of a more assertive approach. DeSantis short-circuited the usual process for state supreme court nominations, allowing him to cement a conservative majority that would be unlikely to overturn his policies, as previous courts had done to his predecessors. He used a new, aggressive interpretation of his powers under state law to remove local elected officials, including Scott Israel, the Broward County sheriff whose response to the Parkland school shooting drew criticism. Previous governors had reserved that right for officials who broke the law, and a state senate special master recommended that Israel be reinstated, but DeSantis pushed through the removal. DeSantis' support for Everglades funding may have been less about the environment than getting back at the powerful sugar industry, whose generous subsidies he had opposed since his days in Congress and which had spent more than $10 million backing Putnam in the primary. "Sugar is more powerful than Disney here, by far, and he took them on unapologetically," says Nick Iarossi, a Tallahassee lobbyist and DeSantis ally.

But it was the pandemic, critics and supporters agree, that changed DeSantis. After initially shuttering schools and restaurants, DeSantis grew frustrated by the lack of clear guidance from Washington and the medical establishment. He began doing his own research and soon concluded that much of the early conventional wisdom about COVID-19 was wrong. The spread of the virus could be mitigated but not contained, he believed. Democratic Governor Andrew Cuomo of New York was being hailed by the media for his strong leadership even as he sent infected elderly people back to nursing homes, an act of tragic malfeasance intended to prevent a hospital-bed shortage that never materialized. Studying the emerging medical data, DeSantis concluded such fears were based on faulty models, and he almost certainly saved lives by isolating elderly patients. He soon reopened Florida's beaches, schools, and businesses while prioritizing protections, vaccines, and treatments for the most vulnerable citizens.

Gaetz, who talked to DeSantis daily during this period, says the governor often brought up the 1918 Spanish flu pandemic, in which people were wheeled onto beaches for sunlight and ventilation. He fretted about the long-term mental-health effects of shutting people indoors and became emotional describing nursing-home residents

dying in isolation, prohibited from seeing their loved ones. DeSantis had surveyed the landscape, watched a stampede of governors go one way, and determined he would do the opposite. “It was very binary,” Gaetz recalls. “One group was going to be toast. The other was going to be vindicated.”

The crisis hit right after the 2020 legislative session had concluded. Rather than call back the frightened lawmakers to address it, DeSantis seized new powers for himself. Declaring a state of emergency, he claimed unfettered authority to allocate pandemic funds from the federal government. He overrode local governments and school boards that tried to impose closures or mask mandates, and threatened to remove or withhold pay from local officials who sought further restrictions.

Once receptive to input from outside his orbit, he became convinced of his own rightness. “COVID was definitely the switch that flipped, when he started to become a bully,” says Nikki Fried, who served at the time as agriculture commissioner, the only Democrat elected statewide alongside DeSantis. Having initially welcomed her outreach, she says, during COVID-19 he stopped returning her calls. Fried, who now chairs the state Democratic Party, began calling DeSantis a “dictator.”

At a dinner in Austin in January 2021, Iarossi introduced DeSantis to Elon Musk. The two men proceeded to discuss disease vectors and biotherapies in obsessive detail. DeSantis “was getting the sh-t kicked out of him on CNN,” Iarossi recalls. “And he said to me, ‘Nick, I don’t care what they say about me now. I care what they say six months from now. I’ve done the research, and I think I’m right.’” At the time, loosening restrictions seemed like a risk, but DeSantis’ confidence was unshakable. “Everyone’s in hysteria thinking the world is going to end, all his advisers are telling him not to. But business thrived, the economy thrived, people moved here. It took a year, not six months. But he was right.”

As Trump left office and the pandemic waned, the governor grew more emboldened. In 2021 and 2022, the legislature pushed through DeSantis-backed bills to make it harder to vote, ban vaccine passports, and crack down on “rioting” at protests. The “parental rights in education” bill, better known as “Don’t Say Gay,” prohibited the teaching of sex and gender in early elementary grades, while the Stop WOKE act banned the teaching of critical race theory (CRT) at schools and businesses. DeSantis signed a 15-week abortion ban, contingent on the yet-to-come reversal of *Roe v. Wade*, and began to express skepticism about the COVID-19 vaccines, appointing a new state surgeon general, Joseph Ladapo, who opposed vaccine and mask mandates while promoting unproven treatments.

Favor-trading was not DeSantis’ style; loyalty was not necessarily returned. At the end of one legislative session, he proceeded to theatrically veto budget priorities of the legislative leaders standing alongside him on the stage.

When it came time to redraw the state’s congressional districts in 2022, legislators proposed a new map that largely preserved the delegation’s balance. A voter-approved constitutional amendment prohibited partisan gerrymandering and sought to protect minority districts, and lawmakers were wary of being slapped down by the

courts if they went too far. But DeSantis had read the relevant laws and precedents, and in January 2022 he proposed his own map, which eliminated a majority-Black district in north Florida and gave the GOP a shot at up to four additional seats in Congress.

None too keen on this attempt to usurp their traditional responsibility, legislators ignored DeSantis and passed their own map instead. DeSantis vetoed it. At the same time, he let it be known that Senate president Wilton Simpson, who was running for agriculture commissioner, might not get his endorsement if he didn't go along. Finally, the legislature relented and passed DeSantis' map. A few days later, DeSantis endorsed Simpson, and another Republican candidate who had been running for the post dropped out. (The map, which governed the 2022 elections, still faces court challenges.)

The redistricting fight was pure DeSantis. "He did that single-handedly—nobody pushed him—and he was relentless," one current GOP lawmaker told me. Brian Ballard, a powerhouse lobbyist in Tallahassee and D.C. and an ally of both Trump and DeSantis, says the gambit cemented his dominance. "The [state] senate didn't lay down for him at first. But he showed he was able to use his political popularity in a way that previous governors had not, and it's brought him incredible power."

DeSantis' chief of staff, James Uthmeier, says he has never seen a policymaker so hands-on. "He sits and talks through the nitty-gritty of policy and the budget," says Uthmeier, who previously served as a senior official in Trump's Commerce Department. "He's ingrained in the process in a way I haven't seen working in the Trump Administration or with other public officials."

With polls showing DeSantis' approval ratings among Florida Republicans in the 90s, he moved to spend his skyrocketing political capital. Traditionally, the state senate caucus had recruited candidates for office and funded their campaigns, but DeSantis had other ideas. In statehouse races in the Tampa and Jacksonville areas, he announced his own handpicked candidates, prompting those backed by the senate to drop out. Republicans who went against him drew complaints from their constituents. In the 2022 election cycle, several Florida political consultants told me, their research found DeSantis' endorsement to be the single most important attribute for GOP primary voters. "In 2020, every member in a strong Republican seat campaigned with a picture of Donald Trump," says GOP state representative McFarland. "In 2022, they campaigned with a picture of Ron DeSantis."

His political aims didn't stop at the statehouse. In another unprecedented move, he issued a raft of down-ticket endorsements as well. Working with the conservative parents'-rights group Moms for Liberty, he backed slates of school-board challengers in districts across the state, targeting boards that had tried to impose school closures and mask mandates during the pandemic. He moved to fill the state bureaucracy with the like-minded, stacking traditionally nonpartisan university and hospital boards with right-wing warriors like the anti-critical-race-theory activist Christopher Rufo. When a locally elected Democratic prosecutor announced he would not enforce DeSantis' abortion and transgender policies, DeSantis removed him based on his own reading of the relevant statutes. (A

court ruled that the rights of the prosecutor had been violated, but that his dismissal could stand.)

DeSantis and his aides went to war with the press, ignoring media requests or publicizing inquiries they considered off-base on Twitter, urging fans to swarm and harass reporters. At press conferences, he delights in berating members of the “corporate media,” often challenging the premise of their questions and accusing them of bias. He scrupulously avoids the mainstream media, once theatrically turning down an invitation to appear on *The View*. This year, DeSantis’ proposal to make it easier to sue media outlets for libel was one of a handful of initiatives the legislature balked at. (DeSantis’ staff did not respond to multiple requests to interview him for this article.) At the same time, DeSantis carefully tends his image in conservative media. He appears frequently on Fox News, once granting the channel exclusive rights to cover a bill signing, and doles out interviews and exclusives to right-wing influencers and publications. A pair of local digital outlets, Florida’s Voice and the Florida Standard, popped up shortly after DeSantis was elected, helmed by writers with backgrounds in conservative activism. Their funding sources are unknown, but with DeSantis’ help, they frequently break news about the governor, forcing the rest of the press corps to follow their lead. The strategy has made him a household name to the national GOP base, and he attracts large crowds at appearances across the country.

DeSantis' policies drew the notice of other red-state governors across the country, who began to see Florida as a laboratory for conservative policy. A raft of states have introduced legislation mirroring "Don't Say Gay," and many have followed his lead with bans on transgender athletes and CRT. His battle with Disney has galvanized a national GOP war on "woke" business practices like environmental, social, and governance (ESG) investing. DeSantis donor retreats in Fort Lauderdale last July and Palm Beach in February were styled as policy conferences, with attendees including GOP governors. He was not the first Republican governor to transport border-crossing migrants to liberal cities—a gambit the Trump Administration had considered but rejected as too extreme—but by flying them to tony Martha's Vineyard, he managed to up the ante.

"What DeSantis has done which his predecessors did not do is exploit all of the power inherent in the office of the governor," says Mac Stipanovich, a longtime GOP lobbyist and operative in Tallahassee who left the party after Trump's election. "Just because you have the right to do something doesn't make it right, and his predecessors were conscious of that. There were guardrails. But if he has the right he doesn't hesitate—and the voters like a strongman."

As a popular governor with a weak Democratic opponent, DeSantis was virtually guaranteed to win re-election in 2022. But he craved something bigger. With a war chest of more than $100 million, he instructed his campaign that he wanted to run on his record. Admakers were told to focus on his policies—even the ones that didn't poll well in isolation. The campaign ultimately produced some 70 different commercials, each looking backward at the accomplishments of DeSantis' first term. Not a single ad focused on his promises for the future.

DeSantis took the resulting landslide as vindication. If past editions of the legislature tended to do DeSantis' bidding, this year's session—with a GOP supermajority in both the state house and senate stacked with newcomers he handpicked—was engineered to work his will. DeSantis passed down a list of more than 40 legislative priorities and pushed the lawmakers to get started early. Twice before the official March kickoff, he called special sessions to knock out priorities that could have waited, like insurance reform.

Tallahassee observers believe the flurry was choreographed to tee up the launch of a presidential bid that will place his policy record at its center. But unlike the legislative session, the pre-campaign has not gone according to plan. DeSantis stumbled on foreign affairs out of the gate, drawing harsh criticism for a statement that

described Russia's invasion of Ukraine as a "territorial dispute." Trump has savaged him in personal terms. Some Republicans worry that DeSantis' rush to the right on issues like abortion may come back to bite him.

Even allies wonder if DeSantis is cut out for the intense human interaction required in a national campaign. An April trip to D.C. to meet with his former colleagues in Congress ended disastrously, producing a flood of anecdotes about his antisocial ways on Capitol Hill and a slew of new congressional endorsements for Trump. The same bunker mentality that has made DeSantis more feared than loved, enabling him to shut out distractions and dismiss the naysayers, has created an insular operation struggling to do the outreach a presidential campaign requires. His stiff-arming of mainstream media has made it difficult to regain control of the narrative. And Trump's political rise would seem to show that policy, substance, and governing experience may not count for much in today's GOP.

But those who have had a front-row seat to DeSantis' transformation of his state know better than to underestimate him. In his presidential run, allies say, will draw on his Florida record to argue he is both more effective and more electable than Trump. To GOP partisans hungry for confrontation but weary of losing, he offers Trumpian aggressiveness without all the baggage. "What got him here isn't personality, it isn't gladhanding," says Iarossi. "It's the relentless pursuit of conservative policies that have made Floridians' lives better and led to a majority of registered Republicans. It's the result of policies and governing." —*With reporting by* Leslie Dickstein *and* Julia Zorthian

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The U.S. Surgeon General Fears Social Media Is Harming the ‘Well-Being of Our Children’

Alice Park is a senior health correspondent at TIME. She covers the COVID-19 pandemic, new drug developments in cancer and Alzheimer's disease, mental health, HIV, CRISPR, and advances in gene therapy, among other issues in health and science. She also covers the Olympics, and co-chaired TIME's inaugural TIME 100 Health Summit in 2019. Her work has won awards from the New York Press Club, and recognition from the Deadline Club. In addition, she is the author of *The Stem Cell Hope: How Stem Cell Medicine Can Change Our Lives*.

On May 23, U.S. Surgeon General Dr. Vivek Murthy issued an advisory warning about the impact that social media is having on the mental health of young people.

“I issued this advisory because this is an urgent crisis,” Murthy tells TIME. “In the effort to maximize the benefit and minimize the harms of social media on children, we have not made enough progress. As a consequence, I worry about the mental health and well-being of our children.”

In a conversation with TIME, Murthy discusses how parents, policy makers, researchers, and technology companies can and should come together to make social media platforms safer for children. (This interview has been condensed and edited for clarity.)

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TIME: Why do you think social media's impact on young people is so concerning?

Since becoming Surgeon General, I have focused primarily on mental health and well-being, which I see as the defining public health crisis of our time.

And youth are a point of concern. As I traveled around the country and talked to families about mental-health concerns, the No. 1 question I get from parents is about social media: "Is social media safe for my kids?" And many kids raise the same concerns. At roundtables I've had with middle-school students, high-school students, and college students, they often proactively bring up social media.

Read More: *How to Start Teaching Your Kids About Social Media*

The three things they have told me most consistently are: 1. That social media often made them feel worse about themselves; 2. That it made them feel worse about their friendships; and 3. That they couldn't get off of it. As one student told me, "I feel great during the day, then take out my phone and get on social media and see all of these people doing things without me, or accomplishing

incredible things—having incredible bodies and living incredible lives—and suddenly I feel worse about myself." It's a common theme.

The reason I issued the advisory is to answer the question that so many parents have been posing to me about social media.

What does your report conclude about social media and youth mental health?

After putting together the available data, which involved going through publicly available research and looking at published data as well as consulting independent experts, our conclusions are, first, that there isn't enough data to say that social media platforms are safe for kids, and, second, that there is growing evidence that social media use is associated with harms.

Do policy makers and technology companies have a responsibility to ensure that their platforms are safe for children?

I 100% see this as a responsibility for policy makers and technology companies. Any company that produces a product consumed by kids has a fundamental responsibility to ensure it is safe for children—that it helps and not harms them.

We don't ask parents to inspect the brakes on cars that children will ride in, or the ingredients in medications that children use, or ask them to conduct chemical analyses of the paint used in toys made for children to make sure that they are safe. We set standards and enforce them—that's usually done by government—to make sure that manufacturers meet them.

That’s what is missing here. We can’t have technology companies set their own standards; we don’t do that in any other sectors where kids’ well-being is at stake. But that’s largely what has been happening over the past 20 years.

What are some specific standards that policy makers can set for social media use among children?

We need to strengthen protections for kids through safety standards, especially by protecting kids from exposure to harmful content. Too many kids are exposed to sexual and violent content, as well as harassment and abuse online. That should not be happening.

We can take a page out of safety standards applied to other products for children, and should include standards around age. While 13 is the commonly used age many platforms use to allow users to join, we should keep in mind two things. First, it’s terribly enforced, because 40% of eight to 12 years olds are on social media. Second, 13 [years old] did not come from a health assessment that looked at what appropriate age kids should be on social media. It came from COPPA [Children’s Online Privacy Protection Rule], a law that restricted the age under which data could not be collected and shared. We need to understand what appropriate age a child should start using these platforms.

Are there data to inform at what age children can safely start using social media?

That’s another thing that standards set by policy makers can do: ensure that technology companies share data that’s relevant from their platforms. I hear from researchers all the time who are not able to get full access to the data they need to fully understand the

impact platforms are having on children. As a parent myself, I don’t want to feel that there is information that is hidden from me about the impact products my kids are using may have on their mental health and well-being.

Read More: *For Teens, Saving Each Other From Social Media Is a Team Effort*

Should standards also include restrictions on certain types of content for younger users?

Effective standards would protect kids from harmful content. And these standards not only need to be set but need to be enforced. It’s important for parents and kids to be at the table to help inform how these standards are shaped.

These platforms have been designed to maximize how much time kids are spending on them. One thing new standards can do is to minimize the features that lead to excessive use, especially among younger children.

I acknowledge that companies are trying to take steps to make platforms safer, but it’s really not sufficient. Time matters. Children only have one childhood, and every day, every month, every year matters in the life and development of a child.

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What Erdoğan's Victory Means for Turkey—and the World

Yasmeen Serhan is a staff writer at TIME, based in the London Bureau. She covers foreign affairs with an emphasis on the future of democracies and rising authoritarianism around the world.

The Erdoğan era lives on. This much was assured on Sunday after Turkey's longtime leader Recep Tayyip Erdoğan emerged victorious in the presidential runoff against opposition challenger Kemal Kılıçdaroğlu.

That Erdoğan managed to survive the single biggest test to his leadership is remarkable given the state of Turkey's economy and lingering public anger over the government's response to powerful earthquakes in February that left at least 50,000 people dead. What his victory means for Turkey's future, as well as the wider world, is the question now on many minds.

For Turkey, Erdoğan's third and final term will mean "a continuation of today," says Galip Dalay, an associate fellow at the London-based Chatham House think tank. Under Erdoğan, who

first came to power as Turkey's Prime Minister in 2003 (a role in which he served for 11 years before becoming President in 2014), the country has backslid into authoritarianism. He has consolidated power through constitutional changes, eroded the country's democratic institutions, including the judiciary and the media, and jailed opponents and critics, many of them journalists. His efforts have earned Turkey the designation of being one of the world's top 10 autocratizing countries, according to Sweden's V-Dem Institute. In 2018, Freedom House downgraded the country's status from "partly free" to "not free."

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With a further five years at the helm, it's unlikely that Erdoğan will choose to change tack on his domestic agenda. If anything, he is likely to go even further. "When autocrats face an unstable domestic context, they double down on repression," says Gönül Tol, the author of *Erdoğan War: A Strongman's Struggle at Home and in Syria*. While Erdoğan could plausibly bow to pressure to return to more orthodox economic policies in order to restore financial stability in the country (a move that he appeared to foreshadow by including his former economic czar, Mehmet Şimşek, at a campaign event), Tol says that Erdoğan is unlikely to relent when it comes restoring the country's democratic credibility. "We've come to a point [where] he's undermined rights and institutions to such an extent that we cannot call Turkey a democracy anymore," she says, noting international electoral observers' verdict that Turkish elections, while ostensibly free and competitive, are nonetheless unfair. "We are coming to a point where Turkey will turn into a country where elections may not matter."

The repercussions of Erdoğan's victory won't just be confined to Turkey. It will have major international consequences—not least for NATO. Unlike the alliance's other members, Turkey has gone out of its way to forge close ties with Russia. In 2017, Ankara controversially agreed to purchase an S-400 missile defense system from Moscow. While most other countries have sanctioned Russia in the aftermath of its full-scale invasion of Ukraine, Turkey has continued to do business with Moscow. In a recent interview with CNN, Erdoğan touted his "special relationship" with Russian President Vladimir Putin and reaffirmed Turkey's lone opposition to Sweden joining NATO. (Ankara previously blocked Finland and Sweden from joining the military alliance, citing concerns over their support for Kurdish militants that Turkey and the U.S. consider terrorist organizations; while it ultimately lifted its opposition to Finland, who has since become NATO's 31st member, its veto on Stockholm's accession stands.)

Over the next five years, "You'll see the strengthening of that [Erdoğan-Putin] relationship further," Tol says. "He's used the Sweden and Finland accession into NATO as a trump card to extract concessions from the Western world. And he has in many ways, so he's going to try to milk that further."

Still, most analysts expect that Erdoğan will ultimately acquiesce to Swedish membership—if not before NATO's upcoming Vilnius summit in July, then perhaps by the end of the year. "Erdoğan cherishes Turkey's presence in NATO because he thinks that it gives him further leverage in international affairs," says Dalay. Indeed, Erdoğan has sought to portray Turkey as a valuable diplomatic mediator between Russia and the West, and has pushed to convene peace talks between Russia and Ukraine, just as it helped broker a key grain export deal between the warring countries last year.

Erdoğan's victory could also have decisive consequences for the roughly 3.6 million Syrian refugees in Turkey. While Erdoğan did

not go so far as Kılıçdaroğlu in vowing to expel all refugees from the country—a move the latter made following the first round of voting, in an apparent bid to chip away at his rival's support among nationalists—Erdoğan noted that his government's plans to build hundreds of thousands of homes in northern Syria would facilitate their voluntary return.

As much as a lot will depend on how Erdoğan chooses to define his last term—and, by extension, his own legacy—a lot will also depend on how the world chooses to respond to his victory, particularly the West. In the global battle between democracy and authoritarianism, Turkey is regarded as firmly within the latter's camp, alongside fellow backsliding countries Hungary, India, and Brazil.

"Is the West ready to confront a more authoritarian Turkey?" asks Tol. "Or are they going to keep this transactional relationship and say, 'As long as Erdoğan keeps Syrian refugees in Turkey, we can work with him, we can tolerate him.'"

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Return-to-Office Full Time Is Losing. Hybrid Work Is On the Rise

Alana Semuels is an economic correspondent at TIME. She covers work, consumer spending, retail, gender, and technology. She is a four-time nominee for the Gerald Loeb Award for Distinguished Business and Financial Journalism, and has won awards from the Society of Business Editors and Writers and the Los Angeles Press Club.

You might have thought that by the end of May, with the pandemic officially over, people would be getting back to the office. But a new report suggests that the share of workers in-office full time is actually shrinking as hybrid work is growing.

The share of people in the office full time dropped to 42% in the second quarter of 2023, down from 49% in the first quarter, according to The Flex Report, which collects insights from more than 4,000 companies employing more than 100 million people globally. Meanwhile, the share of offices with hybrid work arrangements hit 30% in the quarter, up from 20% the previous quarter.

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Datawrapper

“It certainly looks like hybrid is gaining share,” says Robert Sadow, the CEO and co-founder of Scoop Technologies, which puts out the Flex report. “There’s an adoption cycle like any other technology—you have early adopters and laggards.”

Work is moving toward what Sadow calls “structured hybrid,” in which there are a set number of days that people are required to come into the office. The average minimum days required is 2.53, with both two days and three days being popular, he says. Tuesday is the most popular day required, followed by Wednesday and Thursday. Few offices require a Friday presence, and only 24% require a Monday presence.

Of course, not all companies are going to accept that they can’t get employees to return to offices for which they have to keep paying rent. Both Twitter and Tesla require full-time office attendance, and Apple is reportedly tracking employee attendance and threatening action against staff who don’t come in. Workers at Disney are required to go into the office four days a week, though thousands signed a petition protesting the policy.

Opponents argue that return to office policies disadvantage people of color and women who are discriminated against in person, and make life more challenging for working parents who don’t want to waste hours commuting and can’t afford space near the office in today’s housing market.

The Flex Report suggests that workplace flexibility differs dramatically depending on the company’s industry, size, and location. Nearly two in three companies that have fewer than 500 employees are fully flexible, meaning employees can be remote if they want. By contrast, only 13% of companies with more than

50,000 employees are fully flexible, though 66% do allow for structured hybrid work.

States in the west and northeast parts of the U.S. have the highest share of companies that are fully flexible, with Oregon, Washington, and Colorado topping the list; Arkansas, Alabama and Louisiana had the highest share of companies that are full time in the office.

There are other signs, in addition to the Flex Report, that five-days-a-week return to office plans are not succeeding. The share of days worked from home, at around 30%, appears to have stabilized at about five times what it was before the pandemic, according to research by Nicholas Bloom, a Stanford professor who studies remote work. That could be a good thing for both employees and employers: One Bloom study found that people who worked from home were more productive and one-third less likely to quit than those who didn't.

Office occupancy in the top 10 most populous U.S. cities was just 49.9% of pre-pandemic levels the first week of May, according to data from Kastle Systems, which tracks keycard swipes across 2,600 buildings. One result of that trend is that consumer spending has plummeted in center cities in places like New York, Los Angeles, and Washington, D.C.—meanwhile, home values in exurbs and suburbs have continued to surge.

The commercial real estate market hasn't completely tanked yet because many companies are signed into long-term leases. What's more, the format of structured hybrid work means they can't dramatically shrink their spaces yet. If every employee comes in three days a week, but they're the same three days a week, the company still needs the same amount of space as it did before the pandemic. It's just paying for empty office space on certain days of the week.

Bloom expects the share of people working from home more frequently to only trend upward as technology advances. With better video calls, augmented reality, and virtual reality, there may start to be less of a difference from working in an office and being at home, he says. Office occupancy rates may go up to 55%, he says, but he predicts they'll start trending down again by the end of 2024.

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The Hidden Role Ordinary Iranians Have Played in the Protests

Revolutions do not happen only in the streets. Yet the outside world knows the uprising in Iran almost entirely through footage uploaded from camera phones—the thousands upon thousands chanting for the fall of the regime in cities and towns across the country, and the regime answering with batons and shotguns.

There has been no window into the kitchens and courtyards where the country's fate will be decided.

"I did not think a country could change so much in three months," says journalist Kay Armin Serjoie, reflecting on returning to Tehran last September after a summer in Germany. Serjoie, who has covered his native country for more than two decades, was not allowed to work as a reporter while he remained in Iran through the arc of the uprising—from the incendiary outbursts of October and early November, through the cold days of December and January, when the regime largely reclaimed the streets and protesters went to ground.

But he remembered what he saw. And, since returning to Europe in the new year, he has written it down:

On an October night, at least 600 security forces are arrayed down a two-mile stretch of Tehranpars Street that has been a focus of protests for weeks. Armor-clad police special forces hold intersections. Revolutionary Guards on high-powered motorcycles swing clubs at protesters who stand their ground. And rotund, middle-aged *basijis*—dragged from behind desks, and slapped into a helmet and camouflage vests—stand outside mosques and government buildings. Plainclothes agents walk among the crowd, summoning the uniformed forces and their tear gas whenever more than a few score young people gather to chant slogans.

The activists, meanwhile, are overwhelmingly young. Many of the women let their hair flow free.

Read More: *Heroes of the Year—The Women of Iran*

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Apart from the two sides, on what everyone knows is a battlefield, a bigger group nonetheless circulates—an almost unending sea of young families, elderly couples and passersby, some just walking up and down the street, some sitting in their cars in the traffic. They are not shouting any slogans, not protesting anything, yet they brave the tear gas, the charges by security forces, the shouts to move along. They act as if it were just another evening and they're out for a spin on the streets, window shopping, but they're also giving cover to protesters—to disappear among them, or hop onto

cars, or into shops, to escape the frenzied charges of security forces.

Then this watchful sea—the silent majority known in Iran as “the gray caste”—fills the space vacated by the fleeing protesters, almost as if none were ever there. Whenever a plainclothes agent singles out a protester, cornering him or her till reinforcements arrive, the standstill cars commence honking, nonstop. Passersby suddenly become immobile. Shouts of “Let them go!” rise to deafening levels, stunning the security forces, and many a time giving the protesters just enough time to slip away. When that happens, traffic begins to move, passersby resume strolling, and suddenly shop windows become interesting again.

This goes on for hours, until the *basij* and Guards, ground down by the time and the realization that they are surrounded only by antagonists, grow either lethargic or so agitated that at times they fight among themselves.

Meanwhile, the people on the sidewalks and in the cars—the people with responsibilities, with families to support; the people on whom the future of Iran will pivot—bide their time, waiting for the protests to produce leadership, specific objectives and definite

plans. At which point, they just might step in and risk what little the Islamic Republic has left them.

Some make their feelings known. At an all-female gym, the cleaning lady is ecstatic every time she sees someone enter without any headcovering. “You are so beautiful, you make the city so beautiful,” she says, fully garbed herself in traditional hijab. “You’ve even made life beautiful. I never dared to talk back to my father, but ever since this has started my daughter stands up to her father whenever he is being unfair, and, just imagine, he actually listens to her now. Who would have thought that possible?”

At the check-in desk, the attendant asks: “Are you Kurdish? You are so brave. Every night I watch videos on Instagram and Telegram showing how Kurdish cities are resisting the regime. It’s so sad, so sorrowful what’s being done to them.”

In the past, the divisions in Iranian society—of class, and ethnicity—helped the regime, which played on nationalism with fears that the ambition of the Kurds of the west, or the Baluchs in the southeast, was separatism. Not this time. In Zahedan, the provincial capital of Baluchistan, protesters chant, “From Zahedan to Kurdistan, I will give my life for Iran.” And the sonic ache of the “*Baraye*” protest song wafts from windows across the entire country. A young man named Shervin Hajipour wrote the ballad of the uprising from the social media posts of fellow Iranians listing the ways life had become intolerable. Just as #MeToo helped women across the world realize they were experiencing the same abuse, *Baraye* helped Iranians in all corners of the country find each other.

Read More: *The 100 Most Influential People of 2023—Shervin Hajipour*

But not everyone is comfortable saying so out loud. As security forces scramble from protest to protest in September, then October, then November, it does not go unnoticed that they often arrive in the refrigerated trucks of Mihan, a dairy with ties to the government. Calls go out to boycott the brand.

At a corner grocery in the capital, the father and son owners who take turns behind the counter are always happy to talk about traffic, sports, Tehran's polluted air. They never talk politics. Yet, suddenly, their dairy case no longer contains Mihan milk or cheese. Why?

"They were returned since their sell-by date had passed," the son replies, detachedly. "Our customers don't buy products like that."

Every night at 9:00 the shouts begin. From rooftops, balconies, and windows of dark rooms, women and men, and sometimes even children, huddled into the dark recesses to avoid inquisitive eyes, shout "*Zan, Zendegi, Azadi*" (Woman, Life, Freedom), followed by "Death to the Islamic Republic" and "Poverty, Corruption, High prices, Onwards to the Overthrow." It started days after Mahsa Amini died in police custody, at age 22, arrested for how she wore her headscarf. Sometimes the chanting goes on for an hour.

In his penthouse apartment, a retired officer in the Revolutionary Guard Corps brushes it off. "This is just to let people let off steam," he tells his neighbors. But as days pass and more people go into the street, he warns that security agencies are noting the main "instigators."

Then, one October night, his own neighbors join in. He dashes into the building courtyard in a frenzy, "You're breaking the building regulations!" No one heeds him. He calls out a neighbor by name. "Ms. —. you can't do this! Be quiet! Stop shouting!"

“It’s none of your business!” she shouts back. The entire street has fallen silent, people watching to see what transpires. The retired officer presses on, demanding that she stop.

“You know what you are?” she answers. “You’re just a little dictator yourself, Mr. —” and she uses his name. “Hey everybody, all together: Death to dictators.” The answering chant startles the Guardsman. After a minute or two of it, he walks away.

The next morning, a neighbor asks why he tried to shout down the women. “Because I know my own people,” he replies, growing earnest. “They have guys who they can give a Kalashnikov and 10 magazines and tell them to go into this building, and those guys won’t stop until they’ve shot their last bullet. And it won’t matter one bit to any of them whether it’s men, women, or children they’re shooting, or if it’s me or a protester. So at least understand why I’m terrified.”

After a few weeks in the streets, the protesters also begin addressing the people in the windows.

“Gray caste, support us!” they chant.

And: “We don’t need spectators!”

From the windows, they keep watching.

In a middle-class Tehran neighborhood, a man asks a 19-year-old neighbor why he endangers his life every night by leading chants in the street and writing slogans on walls.

The young man replies: “Since we were born, we’ve seen how the regime has been gradually sucking the life out of our parents with inflation, price hikes, limitations on social and personal freedoms.

“If I have to go,” he says, “I prefer to go fast.”

His generation has never known hope. Coming of age after the death of the reformist political movement that, for more than a decade, held out the promise of a more humane Islamic Republic, Iranians in their teens and 20s have faced both a more resolutely authoritarian regime and the hardships of economic sanctions imposed by the West over that regime’s nuclear ambitions. Saving every Rial from a minimum-wage job, a young person would need nearly four years to buy the cheapest car in Iran, and 44 years for an apartment. Lovers face arrest for holding hands.

Read More: *Iran Has a Long History of Political Activism and Protest. Here’s What To Know*

The middle-aged neighbor commiserates. He’d participated in protests over the years. But even though the current uprising has reached every corner of Iran, he says, without leaders and a plan it amounts to an “aimless revolt which will end with bloodshed.”

“They say I’m a part of the gray caste, not committing to the revolt, but it’s not that simple,” the man says. “The house I’m living in is not mine, I should have traded in my car years ago, and I’ve been working for more than 20 years. I’m just making ends meet, and

I’m worried, if something happens to me, who’s going to put the bread on the table for my wife and kids?

“I’ve seen so much cruelty from this regime, and one thing I know: the Islamic Republic won’t just pack up and leave like the Shah did in 1979. They’ve got nowhere to go. The roads will turn red with blood before we get rid of them. I don’t want to risk my family’s livelihood to no avail, and I don’t want these kids to sell their lives cheap.”

A few nights later, the younger man goes out to spray-paint slogans and does not come home. His frantic parents search prisons, police stations, hospitals, and morgues. The neighbor is moved — for now, only as far as the window, where he joins the nightly multitudes shouting slogans.

“When the time comes,” he says, darkly, “I will avenge the kid.”

The regime is watched closely for evidence of weakness. The evidence is everywhere. Neighborhoods that historically supplied the militias that put down dissent in the past have themselves become hotbeds of protest. Rallies the government organizes to counter the impression it has lost Iranian society are so paltry that state media Photoshops images of crowds, and state television rolls the same footage over and over, like the background behind a running cartoon character. The Supreme Leader, widely rumored to be gravely ill, chides security forces to do their duty.

But the regime is also ruthless. The death toll compiled by human rights groups, 506 by mid-December, does not take in the grievously wounded, uncounted young people shot-gunned in the face or genitals. Young women who have lost an eye to birdshot post their new looks proudly on Instagram. But their assailants speed away. Though most of the 30,000 people who had been detained will eventually be released, they will go home with stories

of sexual torture, beatings, and treatment so extreme that several die by suicide after being released.

On a cold December night, the security forces on Tehranpars Street begin closing up shop at 8 p.m. There had been a few protests, a junior officer tells a passerby, “but nothing like the nights in the past months, thank God.” His irate commander steps in to flatly deny any “sedition whatsoever tonight.”

The streets of major cities have seemingly been, to some extent, tamed. And yet, even as the number of protesters has fallen, the gray caste continues to show up to offer them cover. And shop owners who in previous years pulled down metal shutters at the first sign of trouble are still open, every night—like the stand selling the Persian soup of noodles and beans known as *aash* around the corner from Tehranpars a couple of nights earlier. A young man, sweating and out of breath from fleeing riot police, pauses to share his frustrations. He sounds like The Kid’s middle-aged neighbor.

“The problem is there is no direction, no planning,” he says, “It’s almost become sporadic, and with the murder the regime is committing every night, the price is too high for what is becoming a blind revolt.”

Iran’s government is called “theocratic” because clerics organized it after the 1979 Revolution, which unwound across most of a year before the Shah fled. But the regime is best understood as an intelligence-security state. Inside Iran, prominent dissidents and natural leaders—scores of activists like Narges Mohammadi, Bahareh Hedayat, and the rapper Toomaj Salehi —have been either bundled off to prison, or so heavily surveilled as to be paralyzed.

“But we had such high hopes from activists and opposition groups in exile,” the protester says. “We thought just like Ukraine they would be able to get Elon Musk’s Starlink internet up and running

by now. At the least they could have made some sort of a coordination committee to organize the protests, to come up with a plan on how to go forward."

Read More*: Inside the Clandestine Efforts to Smuggle Starlink Internet Into Iran*

Starlink dishes, which would allow dissidents a way to avoid state surveillance, are outlawed in Iran. But so were the satellite TV dishes that became a fixture of Iranian life, with popular channels operated by exiles who, for decades, urged the people to rise up. Now that the people have done just that, the protester says, the exiles "spend their time arguing over the name and parameters of a revolution that they've done nothing for."

And yet every night at nine, the windows still fly open. And the chants begin.

"It's not over," says another protester, a literature student in her early 20s. "The fire is still there. It's what in Farsi we call 'fire under the ashes.'"

"In the beginning we would gather on campus and start from there," she says, "but gradually with all the pressure and violence and arrests, the internet blocked like never before, and the

campuses being shut down, we're no longer able to coordinate. We just go out in ones and twos, and hope to still be able to speak to each other the next morning."

Over the previous three months, two of her classmates had been wounded by shotgun blasts, and nearly a dozen from her university simply disappeared. But she'd been on Tehranpars Street a few minutes earlier.

"We will go on," she says again. "Maybe we'll have to change tactics in the short term. We'll probably have to adjust to the situation we're in. But we won't stop. We'll keep stoking the embers of this fire until one day, somehow, we can get the masses back out on the streets, get the gray caste to fully commit. And then this fire will blaze so hard it will incinerate this tyrannical regime."

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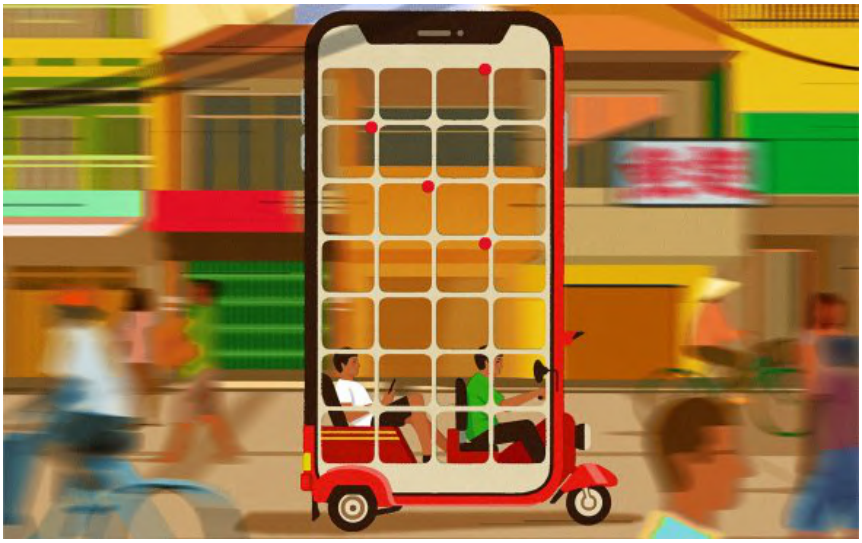
Grab Was Already the Uber of Southeast Asia. Now the ‘Super-App’ Wants to Deliver Financial Equality, Too

Charlie Campbell is a correspondent at TIME, based in the Singapore bureau. He covers business, tech, and geopolitics across Asia. He was previously China Bureau Chief.



The lunchtime rush is just bubbling at Kedai Kopi hawker center in Singapore’s Clementi neighborhood when Anthony Tan strolls in. The co-founder and CEO of the ride-hailing firm Grab orders himself a Horlicks malt drink, sits at a Formica table, and takes a sweep of the bustling vendors. One catches his eye: a stall selling *nasi lemak*, the signature Malay dish of fragrant rice cooked in coconut milk and pandan leaf. Back in 2012, Tan used to offer it to taxi drivers gassing up in his hometown of Kuala Lumpur, pitching his upstart service while they ate.

“But because we couldn’t afford to do a deal with the petrol station, they chased us out,” Tan, 40, recalls. He decamped to a nearby sidewalk by fetid monsoon drains. “It was so smelly,” he says. “But

it was close enough to shout over, ‘Hey uncle, do you want free *nasi lemak*?’”

In the years since, Grab has transformed from a “street fighting” startup, as Tan puts it—scoring Southeast Asia’s biggest Nasdaq IPO in 2021, valued at around $40 billion. But that hasn’t kept Tan sequestered in his office. Opposite the *nasi lemak* stall is another for fiery Peranakan seafood, where Tan pulled a four-hour shift during the pandemic. With lockdowns decimating Grab’s ride-hailing business, it pivoted to food delivery, and Tan wanted to better understand vendors’ needs. He ended up “cleaning live crabs and absolutely covered in bits of shell and crab juice,” he laughs. “But I saw that when the orders came out in -English, the Chinese-speaking chefs couldn’t understand them. After that we made the tickets in both languages.”

Tan’s anecdotes help to explain why Grab, with a market cap of $12 billion, is one of Southeast Asia’s most valuable firms. Its green-attired delivery drivers are ubiquitous in over 500 cities across eight nations. Often compared to Uber, Grab is much more, fast becoming a fully fledged super-app, offering insurance, travel bookings, financial services, and more.

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Tan envisages making Grab a “triple bottom line” company, measuring success not only by its balance sheet but also by its social and environmental impact, particularly through the financial services it now offers. Southeast Asia may be the world’s fastest-growing region economically, but those gains are uneven and 70% of the population is “underbanked,” not relying primarily on traditional banks. Tan’s pitch is that by bringing more small

businesses into the digital economy, he can boost Grab's earnings while fostering equality. "There are many ways you can build social impact and create financial impact—they're not mutually exclusive," he says. "If you don't build a society that's stable, and you don't uplift the bottom, it becomes all of our problem."

Mobility is in Tan's genes. His great-grandfather was a taxi driver and his grandfather an automotive tycoon. After attending Harvard Business School, Tan decided not to join the family business, Tan Chong Motor, which his father runs, but to go it alone. Inspired by classmate and Grab co-founder Tan Hooi Ling's horrific experiences with Kuala Lumpur taxis—by some rankings the world's worst—Tan asked his dad to back their ride-hailing venture but was told "your head is in the clouds," he says. So he went to his mom, who thought the same but still agreed to back him. "Moms are amazing, right?" Still, for a young man born "with a silver spoon," Tan admits, the move was scary. "My dad basically disowned me," he says. "I thought, I'm not going to grovel. I'm going to fight and make sure we win. That was a pivotal moment."

Whereas Uber took a cookie-cutter approach to global expansion, Grab's growth was rooted in being hyper-local. In Cambodia, it offers *tuk-tuks;* in Indonesia, users ride pillion on motor-cycle taxis. While Uber launched delivery ice cream, which often arrived in a slushy mess in the unforgiving tropics, Grab rolled out Southeast Asia's "king of fruits," durian, which remains a huge money spinner. But like any disrupter, Grab has faced pushback. In Thailand, where it operated illegally until rule changes in 2021, local taxi competitors held protests against Grab, brandishing placards of Tan in a coffin: "This job is not for the fainthearted."

Meanwhile, Grab's shares now trade at less than a quarter of their IPO price. Tan puts this down to "timing," given the drying-up of cheap money.

These setbacks haven't deterred Tan. Last August, Grab launched one of Singapore's first digital banks, in partnership with telecom firm Singtel, and is rolling out more across the region. Interest is paid daily instead of monthly, and small loans can be approved in minutes. For Tan, the need was made plain by a conversation at church. A fellow parishioner confessed to spending a stint in Singapore's Changi prison for being a loan shark's goon, who would splash pig's blood on debtors' homes to intimidate them. "He said there were thousands of people like him in Singapore," says Tan. "It's fundamentally wrong to charge somebody 20% a day interest, because you're putting them in a real poverty trap."

The pandemic served as another inflection point. While ride hailing ground to a halt, lockdowns also meant that small businesses had no choice but to embrace digitization. Buoyed by government stimulus packages for small businesses, in just one year Grab added over 600,000 merchants across the region, offering everything from dog bowls to apple strudel. "The COVID crisis became an opportunity for us," says Tan.

It was also a lifeline for people like Suparno, 52, who like many Indonesians uses one name. The father of three owns a tiny fruit stall in Bali's Taman Sari Market, which overflows with lush mangosteen, papaya, and watermelon. When Indonesia shut its borders during the pandemic, tourism-reliant Bali suffered more than most, and Suparno's trade fell 70%, he says. Struggling to feed his family, he became the first vendor in Taman Sari to join GrabMart. By selling his fruit via the app, and using its data-crunching service to bundle in-demand items together, trade quickly recovered to pre-pandemic levels. Today, practically every business in Taman Sari displays a green GrabMart logo, and Suparno plans to open a third stall.

But the leap to digital revealed other benefits. Suparno's business was previously cash-based, which meant carrying around large

wads—a risky proposition—or braving long 9 a.m. queues at the bank before heading to the wholesalers, by which time the best fruit had often been snapped up. Now, any GrabMart sales Suparno makes before midnight appear in his GrabPay account by 4 a.m., meaning he can restock before the bank has even opened. “It helps a lot because mornings are my busiest time,” he says.

It demonstrates how better access to digital financial services helps small businesses compete, which Tan hopes will translate into higher revenue for his firm. Grab’s financial-services revenue grew 233% year over year in the first quarter of 2023, with loan disbursements up 45%. In 2022, small merchants on Grab saw a 26% increase in average monthly earnings after a year on the platform. Still, despite boasting over 32 million monthly users and expecting revenue of $2.2 billion in 2023, Grab has yet to turn a profit, with Tan expecting to finally break even by year’s end. “Grab’s success is also their problem,” says Jeffrey Towson, an investor and consultant on digital strategy in Asia. “They’re dominating the market, with high-frequency services, lots of engagement, which means lots of data. But they’re still struggling to get profitability, because that’s just the nature of the business they’re in.”

Supplementing the low-margin ride-hailing sector with higher-margin add-ons is a main driver behind Tan’s super-app vision. He says it also helps merchants to boost their income through secondary services. Drivers can earn from deliveries but also by hosting advertising brokered via the app, or wearing a helmet camera funneling data to Grab’s own maps offering, which it sells to third parties like Amazon Web Services. Last year, 72% of Grab’s drivers earned from more than one of its services, while over a million took part in one of its 2,500 training and upskilling courses. “When we create more inclusion, society benefits,” says Tan. “What’s good for society is good for business.”

Correction, June 1.

The original version of this story misstated when Grab is expecting $2.2 billion in revenue. That figure is for 2023, not 2022.

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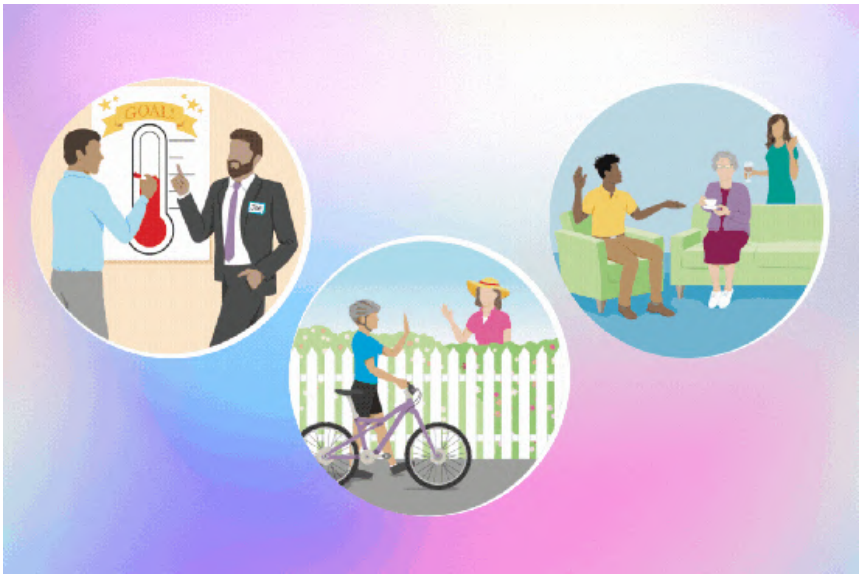
7 Ways to Get Better at Small Talk—And Why You Should

Angela Haupt is a health and wellness editor at TIME. She covers happiness and actionable ways to live well.



When Gillian Sandstrom was a graduate student in Toronto more than a decade ago, she encountered a stranger on the subway who was carrying a scrumptious-looking cupcake.

Sandstrom had long considered herself an introvert and found small talk uncomfortable and even embarrassing. But drool-worthy desserts can't go unadmired, so she approached the woman. "By the end of the conversation, she taught me that people can ride ostriches," she recalls. "That's what conversations do sometimes—and I was hooked after that."

The experience inspired Sandstrom, a senior lecturer in the psychology of kindness at the University of Sussex in England, to conduct some of the leading research on the benefits of casual interactions with strangers and acquaintances. These brief but pleasant exchanges can enhance health and happiness, lifting

mood, energy, and overall well-being. They often promote learning, expand people's world views, and contribute to a sense of belonging. Plus, they're good for both parties: Sandstrom's research indicates that people view "minimal social interactions" such as a smile, compliment, or quick chat as an act of kindness.

You can maximize these benefits by making a point to talk to a wide range of people, additional research suggests. Chatting with your colleagues, barista, Uber driver, and the person surveying the ice-cream aisle with you builds what's called relational diversity, which is a unique predictor of well-being.

Despite the benefits, many of us hate small talk. We often assume that the people around us aren't interested in talking or won't like us—but research indicates that we tend to underestimate how much our conversation partners enjoy our company, a phenomenon called "the liking gap."

"We all have this negative voice in our heads that tells us we're not very good at this social stuff," Sandstrom says. "But the data suggest that people actually like you more than you think they do."

The more you do it, she's found, the more natural it will feel. One study by Sandstrom found that when people did a week-long scavenger hunt in which they had to find, approach, and talk to strangers, they grew more optimistic and confident about their conversational skills every day.

We asked experts to share their favorite strategies for getting better at small talk—because there's only so much you can say about the weather.

Reframe the conversation as a treasure hunt

Alison Wood Brooks gets excited about small talk—and for years, it didn't occur to her that some people dreaded it. But when she

started teaching a course on conversation skills at Harvard Business School, she realized she had hit a nerve. “Even these high-achieving, brilliant MBA students—so many of them hate small talk,” says Brooks, whose forthcoming book is called *Talk: The Science of Conversation and Art of Being Ourselves*. “I’ve come to believe that I’m the weird one. I think most people truly dread small talk and struggle to figure out how to manage it.”

One key to changing that is to first accept that these casual chats are inevitable. “It’s a social ritual that you actually have to engage in, especially with strangers or people you don’t know that well,” she says. Then, reframe it in your mind as a treasure hunt. Dive in, eager to discover what fascinating or juicy tidbit you might unearth. Who knows where the conversation might lead?

Take advantage of “free information”

Lean into your surroundings, says Debra Fine, an expert on communication skills and author of *The Fine Art of Small Talk*. If you’re standing next to someone at a baby shower, for example, the fact that you’re both there is what she describes as “free information”—so ask the person how they know the mom-to-be. If you’re at a fundraiser, ask the stranger assigned to your dinner table how he got involved and what keeps him interested. Or ask the person squeezed into the airplane seat next to you if she’s been to your shared destination before. “If I’m at a 5K race this summer, I’ll say to the person next to me, ‘What’s your best ingredient for success at these things?’ Or, ‘Have you ever done this before?’” Fine says. Your shared reality is a terrific entry point and can lead to deeper conversation.

Don’t linger too long on low-priority topics

Think of conversation topics as a pyramid, Brooks says. The foundation consists of the obligatory small talk anyone can master:

How about that rain? How was your weekend? These topics are foundational, she says—you often have to start conversations at the base of the pyramid.

The mistake people commonly make, however, is lingering there too long. “You get stuck talking about the weather for 15 minutes,” and all parties become desperate to escape, she says. Instead, ascend the pyramid by selecting topics that are increasingly more personalized and tailored to your conversation partner. Say you ask a colleague how their weekend was, and they tell you they went to a Taylor Swift concert. “As soon as you find that treasure, there are so many questions you can ask,” Brooks says. For example: *What was your favorite part of the show?* “And then all of a sudden you’re sprinting up the pyramid away from small talk, because they’re going to talk about their emotions and peak moments,” she says. Voila: small talk has evolved into deep talk.

Compliment unique forms of personal expression

Try not to comment on someone’s looks, which could come across as “creepy,” Sandstrom says. (For example: Avoid “you have such beautiful eyes,” which might make the recipient want to shuffle away as quickly as possible.)

Instead, channel your curiosity about a form of personal expression—like funky jewelry or hair color, or a striking outfit or bag—into a compliment that might start a conversation. “When you give someone a compliment, like ‘Oh, I love your tattoo,’ they often interpret it as, ‘You’re asking me the story about it,’” she says.

Sandstrom once complimented a waitress on her earrings, and the woman told her how she collects a new set everywhere she travels. That particular pair happened to be shaped like sailboats—and had been made out of old boat materials. The exchange brightened each person’s day, and remains vivid in Sandstrom’s mind.

Skip questions about marriage, kids, and work

When you're talking to strangers and acquaintances, it's generally wise to steer clear of controversial topics (like religion and politics) and to avoid probing potentially sensitive matters (such as inquiring if someone is married or has kids). Another possible landmine: Asking someone what they do for work. Not only is it a tired line of inquiry, but it could thrust someone into the uncomfortable position of, say, disclosing they were recently laid off.

Instead, try a question like: "'What keeps you busy outside of work or school?'" Fine advises. For acquaintances, use phrases like "catch me up on" or "bring me up to speed." For example: You might ask a high-school senior to fill you in on their college search, rather than inquiring if they got into Dartmouth.

When someone asks you a question, respond generously

Think of conversation as a game—and aim to be an active player, which requires investing energy into it. If someone asks you how you are, and you simply respond "good," you're being a "lazy conversationalist," Fine says. Rather than a single-word response, offer a full sentence in return, like: "I just watched the most recent episode of *Ted Lasso*, and I didn't think it was that great." That gives the person you're talking to plenty to work with if they'd like to continue to chat.

Exit the conversation gracefully

People often drag conversations on for too long because they can't figure out how to end them, Brooks says.

While the exact circumstances will dictate how you navigate your exit, consider introducing the person to someone else, suggests Diane Windingland, author of several books on communication skills, including *Small Talk, Big Results*. Make a positive comment about why they should meet, and then say, “I’ll let you two get to know each other.”

If that’s not possible, briefly recap the conversation—“I enjoyed hearing about your fishing adventures”—and, if you want, mention something you could do together in the future. Then, Windingland recommends concluding like this: “Please excuse me; I have to talk to so and so.” Or, “It’s been great talking to you, but I don’t want to monopolize your time.”

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J. Harrison Ghee and Alex Newell on Making Tony History Together

Laura Zornosa is a reporter at TIME. She covers TV, film, books, music, and pop culture. She was awarded a reporting fellowship grant from the Pulitzer Center.

One morning in early May, J. Harrison Ghee and Alex Newell made history as the first nonbinary-identifying actors to be nominated for Tony Awards. Then, a month later, they did it again: On Sunday night, Ghee and Newell became, in quick succession, the first out nonbinary performers to win Tony Awards. (That means that this year, no cis men won Tonys for acting in a musical.)

The night before the nominations were announced was the first time that either performer had attended the Met Gala—or, as Newell calls it, “our Tony nominee party.” A couple weeks later, the pair met with TIME together in a Midtown café close to both of their theaters to discuss the nominations, Ghee for Best Leading Actor in a Musical for their role as Jerry/Daphne in *Some Like It*

Hot and Newell for Best Featured Actor in a Musical for their role as Lulu in *Shucked*.

Neither are newcomers to Broadway. Ghee made their debut as Lola (a drag queen who helps save a failing shoe factory) in *Kinky Boots* in 2017, and Newell made theirs the same year as Asaka (the Earth goddess) in *Once on This Island*. (The two go way back, having met at a performance of *Kinky Boots*.) This year, *Some Like It Hot* and *Shucked* were also both nominated for Best New Musical, meaning that Ghee and Newell originated their roles on-stage, and can make them their own.

Those roles feel tailor-made to their performers: In *Shucked*, Lulu is a small-town whiskey distiller who brings down the house with a standing ovation in the middle of Act I with "Independently Owned," a show-stopper about not needing a man.

Newell says they are learning from Lulu about gradually opening up. "That in my own independent life, there is something else to have, there is another person to be had, that can meld, mesh well into this independent life that I live."

And in *Some Like It Hot*, based on the 1959 Billy Wilder film that starred Marilyn Monroe, Tony Curtis, and Jack Lemmon, two musicians, Jerry (Ghee) and Joe (Christian Borle), must flee Chicago after witnessing a mob hit. They go undercover in drag, joining a traveling all-girl band, but Jerry, the bass player, finds himself drawn to his newfound persona as Daphne.

"Of course, doing *Some Like It Hot* and bringing men in dresses back to Broadway, everybody has feelings," Ghee says. "So they're concerned about how it's going to be perceived and received. And there were moments where I was like, can't we just be artists and create?"

In conversation, Ghee—in a black, strappy, leather top and pleated miniskirt—and Newell—wearing a white, puff-sleeved top and a set of feathery lashes—vamp and riff and ricochet off of each other, toggling seamlessly between thoughtful and funny. They discussed their characters, who their art serves, and what winning really means.

This interview has been edited for concision and clarity.

TIME: J., your dad is a minister; Alex, your dad was a deacon; and you were both in church choirs. How did that specific upbringing shape your journeys?

Ghee: You know how to make the church go up in a way of, “I’m using what I got today.” Using the gift. So it is definitely such a formative way of learning yourself as an artist.

Newell: And your instrument in general. You create your own style in church. The fact that gospel and hymns have their own diaspora inside a genre, that we can have a Lecresia Campbell giving us operatic tones into a belt, and we can have pop from Mary Mary. That’s that artistry of finding yourself and your voice.

You both also have had significant drag experiences, as Madam That Bitch and Crystal Demure. J., you had this beautiful quote that "drag is a tool of freedom." How did drag change your perceptions of yourself?

Ghee: When I started doing drag, I used to say I never imagined myself doing it, which was a complete bold-faced lie. I was young Lola playing in my mom's clothes as a kid, and using blankets as trains and making dresses. And so it was me tapping back into the little version of me, and that freest, most imaginative person, and having complete creative control of how I can be effective with my gifts.

Because I'm always trying to be intentional with everything that I do, and especially with drag, and so it was my way of: How am I ministering to people? How am I reaching hearts and souls and minds through this artistry? So it really helped me free myself in every way.

Newell: Well, you know, I wasn't in drag ever until I won *RuPaul's Secret Celebrity Drag Race*. No, I guess I never knew what drag was for so long, because I didn't know what I was doing when I was putting on my mama's heels and tromping around the house. Honey, I cried the day my foot went past a seven. I cried.

Did doing drag in your late 20s feel different?

Newell: Very different. I always say drag is appreciating the woman's body, in a way. And appreciating what life started out of. To appreciate our moms and our idols and all of that good stuff, and to really exaggerate the beauty of that form and that art.

You each have a number—"Independently Owned" and "You Coulda Knocked Me Over With a Feather"—that showcases both your skills as performers and your characters' emotional journeys. How do you feel on stage as you sing those songs?

Newell: I'll be honest, I'm tired. I am exhausted. Mine is particularly strange, because I do the opening number, I have a 40-minute break, and when I come back on stage, it's the *number*. I'm just like, 'Ah!' And it's such a big thing from zero. I just jump in and feel like I'm shot out of a cannon.

Ghee: By that time, I'm warm. I'm working towards that point in the show. And there are shows where I'm like, "Where am I pulling this from today?" But I get into it and it is that giving into Daphne and that freedom to find the joy every time. And it cracks a part of me open every time.

As you've spent time with your characters, what kind of relationship do you have with them? Has that changed over time?

Ghee: Changes every day. And I love it. I love being able to step in and be like, "OK, what am I finding today?" For them *and* for myself. What kind of freedom? What kind of joy? And bringing myself to the day in the moment, and then also leaving space for exploration and uniqueness. Very intentional of, like, "Oh, this is very close to home and purpose-driven." But then also, how do I expand within this?

Newell: When Lulu's singing the song, it is male-driven, about how this independent woman has done everything without a man.

I've done the same exact thing. I haven't had a partner that's attached to me. It's just been me. And half of that creates a callus over the emotion of not needing anyone.

But then knowing that it's OK to want it and to have it. It is OK to be independent and still have the things that everybody else does. I mean, there is the one line. It's so small, it happens so fast. And it's, "There might be someone that I ain't met yet."

Alex, you've said that Lulu is like you, but heightened. What did you mean by that?

Newell: Well, you know, I modeled my Lulu off of Delta Burke and Julia Sugarbaker. I'm the hybrid of both of them on *Designing Women*. And it's me but heightened in the fact that I am loud. I am very outspoken. But I do have a filter, which is shocking to most. I do think about what I'm going to say. Lulu does not. Lulu, if it comes up, it comes out.

J., I read that you helped shape Daphne. Were you able to tweak her lines or character in a way that felt more true to you?

Ghee: The creative team really trusted me and gave me the space to go. They really were like, "We defer to you."

When I say to Christian [Borle, who plays Joe/Josephine] in Act II, when he's like, "What do I call you? Jerry? Daphne?" And I'm like, "Either is fine, as long as you do it with love and respect." When people ask me my pronouns, I say, "All things, with respect." I understand that the world is conditioned to respond to what they see. So they're always going to immediately say "he/him." But I don't expect you to know what I am feeling and what I am carrying that day. And what I'm presenting doesn't

necessarily attach to what I am. And I walk in the fullness of who I am at all times.

How does the comedic aspect of these musicals help access these deeper conversations?

Newell: You don’t see it coming.

Ghee: Truly.

Newell: You don't see that you're gonna laugh about something that you need to fix.

Ghee: One of my favorites is when Kevin [Del Aguila, who plays Daphne's love interest] says in the show, "The world responds to what they see." And everyone's like, "Yeah, yeah, yeah," and then, "Well, the world doesn't have very good eyesight." And you're like, "Ah. Oh, right. That's very true. In so many ways."

Newell: Ours is just blatant. Our Plan B joke is blatant. Maizie [Lulu's cousin], she needs to find a plan B. Even though most people are trying to put a stop to Plan B. No one's expecting to laugh for two hours and then hear a joke like that. And literally say, "Here's the mirror. If you feel uncomfortable, you're the problem."

You had similar attitudes toward being nominated into gendered Tony categories—but I know the Tonys have also said that they're working to change. What would change look like for you, ideally?

Newell: Baby, I don't know. The change itself is an extremely hard one to make. Because if we sit here and we talk about why the categories were separated at the beginning, it was to give other people than cis white men awards. And we did take gender off of some awards in the U.K., and the only thing that won was cis white men. And I said, "Ooh, we just went right back to where we started." So I don't know what that looks like. It's a deeper conversation. I think it's adding a category, widening the horizon of the category.

Ghee: We've got to free ourselves to see ourselves. We really got to give ourselves the permission to be like, "You know what, we can do whatever we want to do." We do shape society and culture. Let's

be ahead of that, and let us make the room and the space for everybody at the table to do all of the things.

What happens if you win?

Newell: In my spirit, I've already won. Not a statue, not anything. I created a lane for somebody after me to come and do exceptional. I have created space and created conversation and made the ruckus that needs to create active change. If I win, yay, I'll put the statue in my bathroom. And I'll play with it every time I brush my teeth. And I'd love it.

Ghee: But it is exciting to see so many people feeling seen and represented who are like, "Wow, thank you. I didn't know that there was any possibility for me in this world." And I know that feeling of moving to New York. I wasn't a theater kid growing up. I grew up singing in church. And so it was like, well, I sing and dance and people respond; theater sounds right. Let me go try this out. And then to find Billy Porter's album of *At the Corner of Broadway and Soul*, I was like, "Whoa, there is somebody in this industry I can—"

Newell: See! And be!

Ghee: Something to look up to. So to now be that for somebody else? Again, the winning is already happening.

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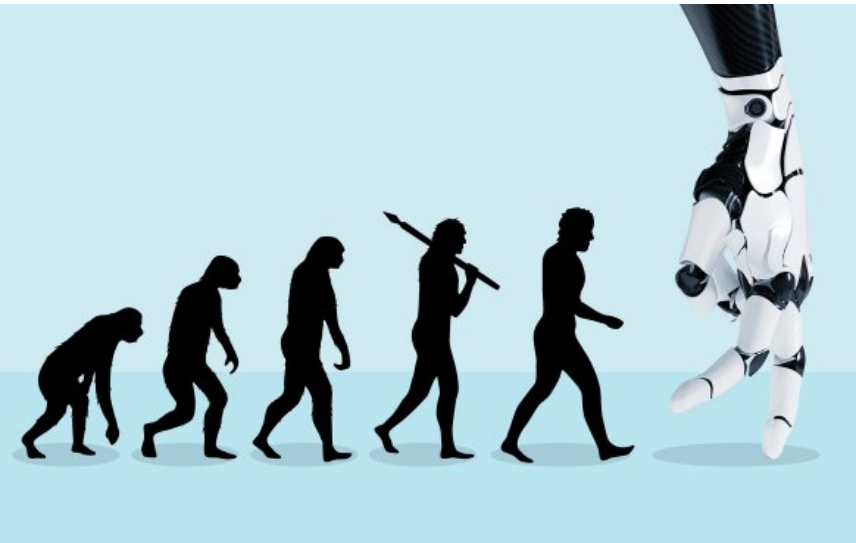
The Darwinian Argument for Worrying About AI

Hendrycks is the director of the Center for AI Safety



A broad coalition of AI experts recently released a brief public statement warning of “the risk of extinction from AI.” There are many different ways in which AIs might become serious dangers to humanity, and the exact nature of the risks is still debated, but imagine a CEO who acquires an AI assistant. They begin by giving it simple, low-level assignments, like drafting emails and suggesting purchases. As the AI improves over time, it progressively becomes much better at these things than their employees. So the AI gets “promoted.” Rather than drafting emails, it now has full control of the inbox. Rather than suggesting purchases, it’s eventually allowed to access bank accounts and buy things automatically.

At first, the CEO carefully monitors the work, but as months go by without error, the AI receives less oversight and more autonomy in the name of efficiency. It occurs to the CEO that since the AI is so good at these tasks, it should take on a wider range of more open-ended goals: “Design the next model in a product line,” “plan a new marketing campaign,” or “exploit security flaws in a

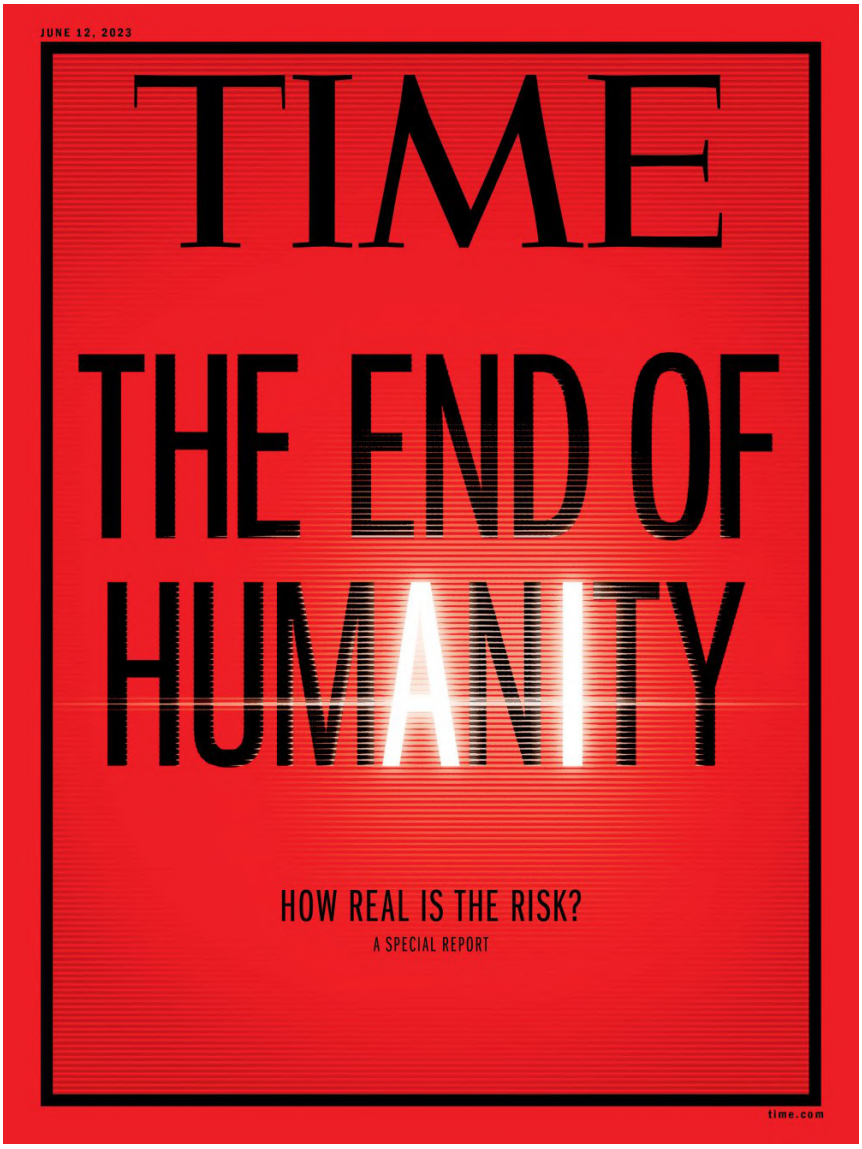
competitor's computer systems." The CEO observes how businesses with more restricted use of AIs are falling behind, and is further incentivized to hand over more power to the AI with less oversight. Companies that resist these trends don't stand a chance. Eventually, even the CEO's role is largely nominal. The economy is run by autonomous AI corporations, and humanity realizes too late that we've lost control.

Read More: AI Is Not an Arms Race

These same competitive dynamics will apply not just to companies but also to nations. As the autonomy of AIs increases, so will their control over the key decisions that influence society. If this happens, our future will be highly dependent on the nature of these AI agents.

The good news is that we have a say in shaping what they will be like. The bad news is that Darwin's laws do too. Though we think of natural selection as a biological phenomenon, its principles guide much more, from economies to technologies. The evolutionary biologist Richard Lewontin proposed that natural selection will take hold in any environment where three conditions are present: 1) there are differences between individuals, 2) characteristics are passed on to future generations, and 3) the fittest variants propagate more successfully.

Consider the content-recommendation algorithms used by social media platforms and streaming services. When particularly addictive algorithms hook users, they result in higher engagement and screen time. These more effective algorithms are consequently "selected" and further fine-tuned, while algorithms that fail to capture attention are discontinued. This fosters the survival of the most addictive dynamic. Platforms that refuse to use addictive methods are simply outcompeted by platforms that do, leading to a race to the bottom among competitors that has already caused massive harm to society.



In the biological realm, evolution is a slow process. For humans, it takes nine months to create the next generation and around 20 years of schooling and parenting to produce fully functional adults. But scientists have observed meaningful evolutionary changes in species with rapid reproduction rates, like fruit flies, in fewer than 10 generations. Unconstrained by biology, AIs could adapt—and therefore evolve—even faster than fruit flies do.

There are three reasons this should worry us. The first is that selection effects make AIs difficult to control. Whereas AI researchers once spoke of “designing” AIs, they now speak of “steering” them. And even our ability to steer is slipping out of our grasp as we let AIs teach themselves and increasingly act in ways

that even their creators do not fully understand. In advanced artificial neural networks, we understand the inputs that go into the system, but the output emerges from a “black box” with a decision-making process largely indecipherable to humans.

Second, evolution tends to produce selfish behavior. Amoral competition among AIs may select for undesirable traits. AIs that successfully gain influence and provide economic value will predominate, replacing AIs that act in a more narrow and constrained manner, even if this comes at the cost of lowering guardrails and safety measures. As an example, most businesses follow laws, but in situations where stealing trade secrets or deceiving regulators is highly lucrative and difficult to detect, a business that engages in such selfish behavior will most likely outperform its more principled competitors.

Selfishness doesn’t require malice or even sentience. When an AI automates a task and leaves a human jobless, this is selfish behavior without any intent. If competitive pressures continue to drive AI development, we shouldn’t be surprised if they act selfishly too.

The third reason is that evolutionary pressure will likely ingrain AIs with behaviors that promote self-preservation. Skeptics of AI risks often ask, “Couldn’t we just turn the AI off?” There are a variety of practical challenges here. The AI could be under the control of a different nation or a bad actor. Or AIs could be integrated into vital infrastructure, like power grids or the internet. When embedded into these critical systems, the cost of disabling them may prove too high for us to accept since we would become dependent on them. AIs could become embedded in our world in ways that we can’t easily reverse. But natural selection poses a more fundamental barrier: we will select against AIs that are easy to turn off, and we will come to depend on AIs that we are less likely to turn off.

These strong economic and strategic pressures to adopt the systems that are most effective mean that humans are incentivized to cede more and more power to AI systems that cannot be reliably controlled, putting us on a pathway toward being supplanted as the earth's dominant species. There are no easy, surefire solutions to our predicament.

A possible starting point would be to address the remarkable lack of regulation of the AI industry, which currently operates with little oversight, much of the research taking place in the dark. Regulation needs to be done proactively rather than reactively; if something goes wrong in this domain, we may not get the chance to fix it.

The problem, however, is that competition within and between nations pushes against any common-sense safety measures. AI is big -business. In 2015, total corporate investment in AI was $12.7 billion. By 2021, this figure had grown to $93.5 billion. As the race toward powerful AI systems quickens, corporations and governments are increasingly incentivized to reach the finish line first. We need research on AI safety to progress as quickly as research on improving AI capabilities. There aren't many market incentives for this, so governments should offer robust funding as soon as possible.

The future of humanity is closely intertwined with the progression of AI. It is therefore a disturbing realization that natural selection may have more sway over it than we do. But as of now, we are still in command. It is time to take this threat seriously. Once we hand over control, we won't get it back.

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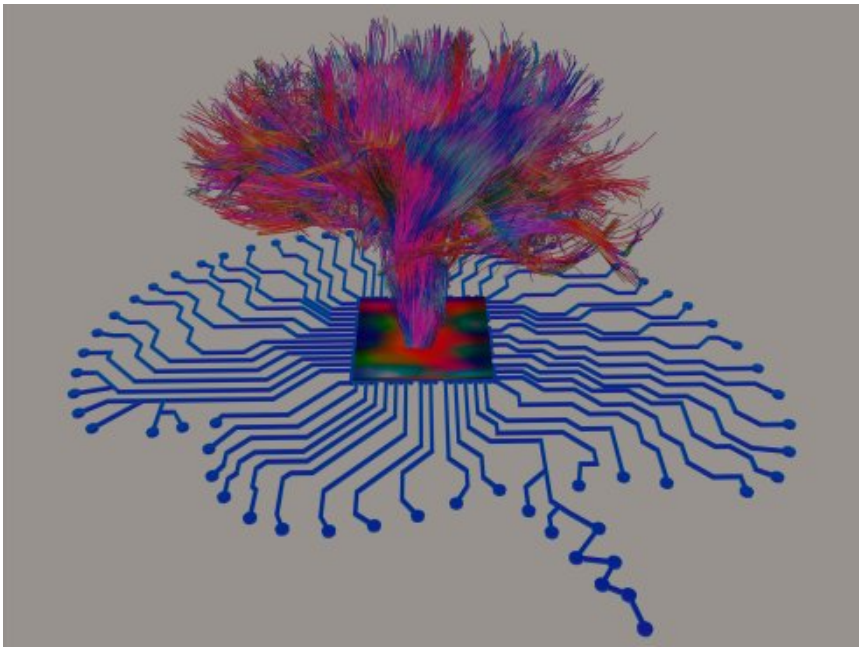
AI Is Not an Arms Race

Grace is the lead researcher at AI Impacts, an AI-safety project at the nonprofit Machine Intelligence Research Institute.

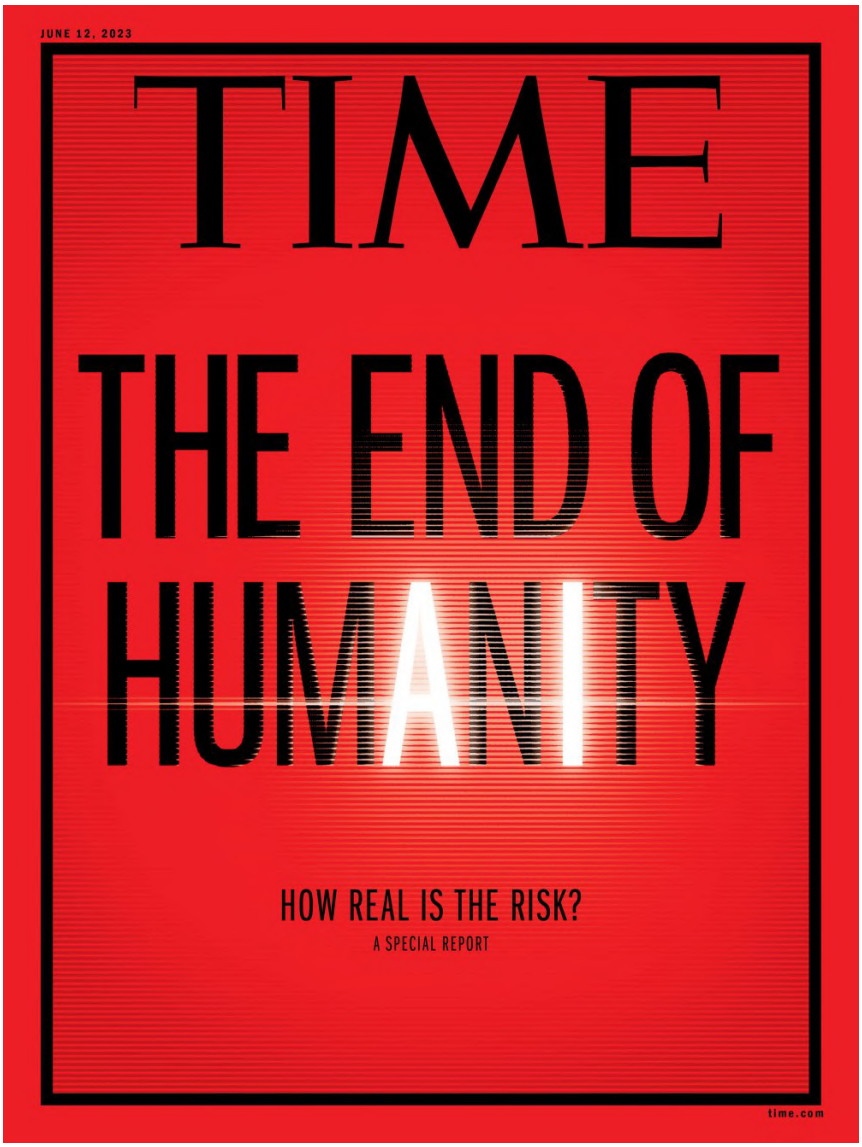


The window of what AI *can't* do seems to be contracting week by week. Machines can now write elegant prose and useful code, ace exams, conjure exquisite art, and predict how proteins will fold.

Experts are scared. Last summer I surveyed more than 550 AI researchers, and nearly half of them thought that, if built, high-level machine intelligence would lead to impacts that had at least a 10% chance of being "extremely bad (e.g. human extinction)." On May 30, hundreds of AI scientists, along with the CEOs of top AI labs like OpenAI, DeepMind and Anthropic, signed a statement urging caution on AI: "Mitigating the risk of extinction from AI should be a global priority alongside other societal-scale risks such as pandemics and nuclear war."

Why think that? The simplest argument is that progress in AI could lead to the creation of superhumanly-smart artificial "people" with

goals that conflict with humanity's interests—and the ability to pursue them autonomously. Think of a species that is to homo sapiens what homo sapiens is to chimps.



Yet while many fear that AI could mean the end of humanity, some worry that if "we"—usually used to mean researchers in the West, or even researchers in a particular lab or company—don't sprint forward, someone less responsible will. If a safer lab pauses, our future might be in the hands of a more reckless lab—for example, one in China that doesn't try to avoid substantial risks.

Read More: *Pausing AI Developments Isn't Enough. We Need to Shut it All Down*

This argument analogizes the AI situation to a classic arms race. Let's say I want to beat you in a war. We both spend money to build more weapons, but without anyone gaining a relative advantage. In the end, we've spent a lot of money and gotten nowhere. It might seem crazy, but if one of us doesn't race, we lose. We're trapped.

But the AI situation is different in crucial ways. Notably, in the classic arms race, a party could always theoretically get ahead and win. But with AI, the winner may be advanced AI itself. This can make rushing the losing move.

Other game-changing factors in AI include: how much safety is bought by going slower; how much one party's safety investments reduce the risk for everyone; whether coming second means a small loss or major disaster; how much the danger rises if additional parties pick up their speed; and how others respond.

Read More: *How the World Must Respond to the AI Revolution*

The real game is more complex than simple models can suggest. In particular, if individual, uncoordinated incentives lead to the sort of perverse situation described by an "arms race," the winning move, where possible, is to *leave the game*. And in the real world, we can coordinate our way out of such traps: we can talk to each other; we can make commitments and observe their adherence; we can lobby governments to regulate and make agreements.

With AI, the payoffs for a given player can be different from the payoffs for society as a whole. For most of us, it may not matter much if Meta beats Microsoft. But researchers and investors chasing fame and fortune might care much more. Talking about AI as an arms race strengthens the narrative that they need to pursue their interests. The rest of us should be wary of letting them be the ones to decide.

Read More: *The 'Don't Look Up' Thinking That Could Doom Us With AI*

A better analogy for AI than an arms race might be a crowd standing on thin ice, with abundant riches on the far shore. They could all reach them if they step carefully, but one person thinks: "If I sprint then the ice may break and we'd all fall in, but I bet I can sprint more carefully than Bob, and he might go for it."

On AI, we could be in the *exact opposite* of a race. The best individual action could be to move slowly and cautiously. And collectively, we shouldn't let people throw the world away in a perverse race to destruction—especially when routes to coordinating our escape have scarcely been explored.

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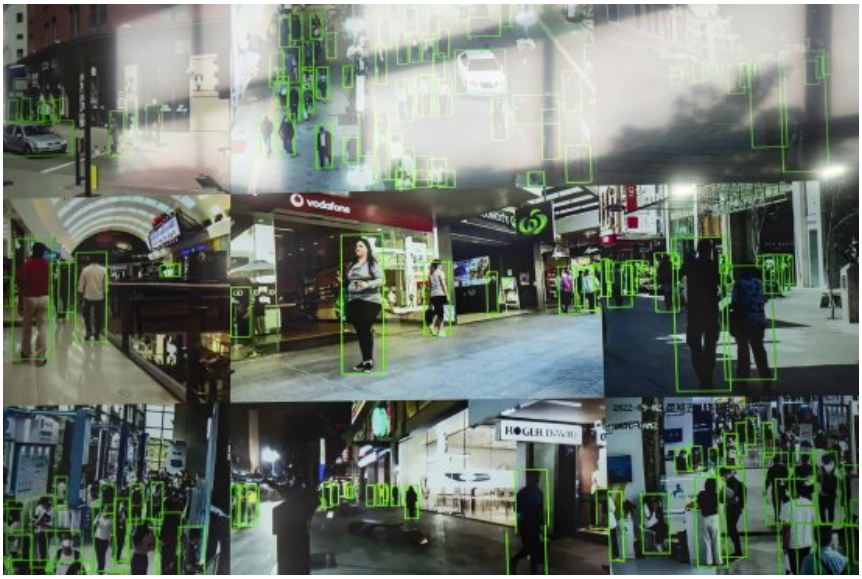
How the World Must Respond to the AI Revolution

Ian Bremmer is a foreign affairs columnist and editor-at-large at TIME. He is the president of Eurasia Group, a political-risk consultancy, and GZERO Media, a company dedicated to providing intelligent and engaging coverage of international affairs. He teaches applied geopolitics at Columbia University's School of International and Public Affairs, and his most recent book is The Power of Crisis.



The now-surging development of artificial intelligence will produce medical breakthroughs that save and enhance billions of lives. It will become the most powerful engine for prosperity in history. It will give untold numbers of people, including generations not yet born, powerful tools their ancestors never imagined. But the risks and challenges AI will pose are becoming clear too, and now is the time to understand and address them. Here are the biggest.

The health of democracy and free markets depends on access to accurate and verifiable information. In recent years, social media

has made it tougher to tell fact from fiction, but advances in AI will unleash legions of bots that seem far more human than those we've encountered to date. Much more sophisticated audio and video deep fakes will undermine our (already diminished) confidence in those who serve in government and those who report the news. In China, and later in its client states, AI will take facial recognition and other tools that can be used for state surveillance to exponentially higher levels of sophistication.

This problem extends beyond our institutions, because the production of "generative AI," artificial intelligence that generates sophisticated written, visual, and other content in response to prompts from users, isn't limited to big tech companies. Anyone with a laptop and basic programming skills already has access to AI models far more powerful than those that existed even a few months ago and can produce unprecedented volumes of content. This proliferation challenge is about to grow exponentially as millions of people will have their own GPT running on real-time data available on the internet. The AI revolution will empower criminals, terrorists and other bad actors to code malware, create bioweapons, manipulate financial markets, and distort public opinion with startling ease.

Artificial intelligence can also exacerbate inequality – within societies between small groups with wealth, access, or special skills, as well as among wealthier and poorer nations.

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AI will create upheaval in the workforce. Yes, technological leaps of the past have mainly created more jobs than they've killed, and they've increased general productivity and prosperity, but there are crucial caveats. Jobs created by big workplace tech changes demand different skillsets than those they've destroyed, and the transition is never easy. Workers must be retrained. Those who can't be retrained must be protected by a social safety net that

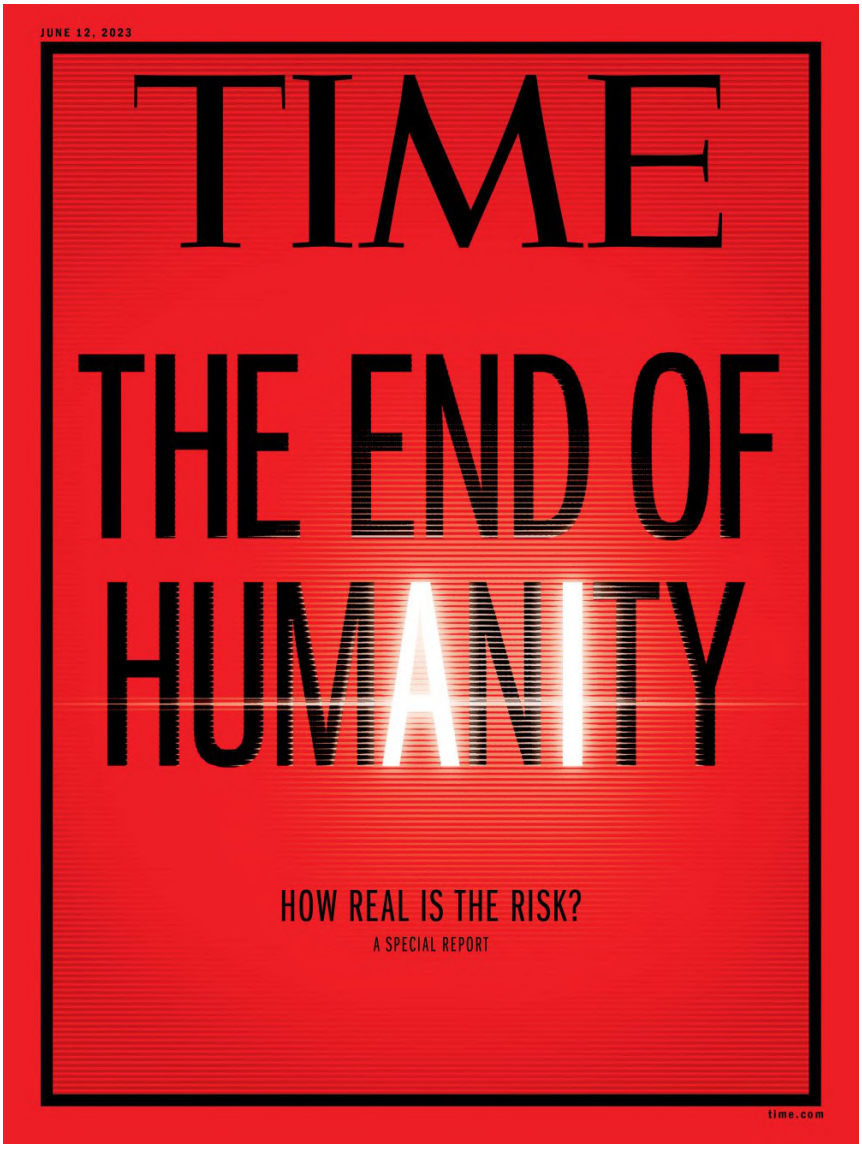
varies in strength from place to place. Both these problems are expensive, and it will never be easy for governments and private companies to agree on how to share this burden.

More fundamentally, the displacement created by AI will happen more broadly and much more quickly than transitions of the past. The turmoil of transition will generate economic, and therefore political, upheaval all over the world.

Finally, the AI revolution will also impose an emotional and spiritual cost. Human beings are social animals. We thrive on interaction with others and wither in isolation. Bots will too often replace humans as companions for many people, and by the time scientists and doctors understand the long-term impact of this trend, our deepening reliance on artificial intelligence, even for companionship may be irreversible. This may be the most important AI challenge.

The response

Challenges like these will demand a global response. Today, artificial intelligence is regulated not by government officials but by technology companies. The reason is simple: You can’t make rules for a game you don’t understand. But relying on tech firms to regulate their products isn’t a sustainable plan. They exist mainly to make a profit, not to protect consumers, nations, or the planet. It’s a bit like letting energy companies lead the way on strategies to fight climate change, except that warming and its dangers are already understood in ways that AI risks are not, leaving us without pressure groups that can help force the adoption of smart and healthy policies.



So, where are the solutions? We'll need national action, global cooperation, and some commonsense cooperation from the US and Chinese governments, in particular.

It will always be easier to get well-coordinated policy within national governments than at the international level, but political leaders have their own priorities. In Washington, policymakers have focused mainly on winning a race with China to develop the tech products that will best support 21st century security and prosperity, and that has encouraged them to give tech companies that serve the national interest something close to free rein. Chinese policymakers, fearful that AI tools might undermine their political authority, have regulated much more aggressively. European rule-

makers have focused less on security or profits than on the social impact of AI advances.

But all will have to make rules in coming years than limit the ability of AI bots to undermine political institutions, financial markets, and national security. That means identifying and tracking bad actors, as well as helping individuals separate real from fake information. Unfortunately, these are big, expensive, and complicated steps that policymakers aren't likely to take until they're faced with AI-generated (but real) crises. That can't happen until discussion and debate on these issues begin.

Read More: The Darwinian Case for Worrying About AI

Unlike on climate change, the world's governments haven't yet agreed that the AI revolution poses an existential cross-border challenge. Here, the United Nations has a role to play as the only institution with the convening power to develop a global consensus. A UN-led approach to AI will never be the most efficient response, but by building consensus on the nature of the problem and pooling international resources, it will help.

By forging agreement on which risks are most likely, most impactful, and emerging most quickly, an AI-focused equivalent to the Intergovernmental Panel on Climate Change can regularize gatherings and the production of "State of AI" agreements that drill ever closer to the heart of AI-related threats. As with climate change, this process will also have to include active participation of public policy officials, scientists, technologists, private-sector delegates, and individual activists representing most member states to create a COP (conference of the parties) process to address threats to biosecurity, freedom of information, health of the labor force, etc. There could also be an artificial intelligence agency modeled on the International Atomic Energy Agency to help police AI proliferation.

That said, there’s no way to address the fast-metastasizing risks created by the AI revolution without an infusion of much-needed common sense into relations between the U.S. and China. After all, it’s the tech competition between the two countries and their lead tech companies that create the greatest risk of war, particularly as AI plays an ever-growing role in military weapons and planning.

Beijing and Washington must develop and sustain highest-level conversations about emerging threats to both countries (and the world) and how best to contain them. And they can’t wait for an AI version of the Cuban Missile Crisis to force them toward genuine transparency in managing their competition. To create an “AI arms control agreement” with mutual monitoring and verification, each government must listen not only to one another but to technologists on both sides who understand the risks that must be contained.

Far-fetched? Absolutely. The timing is terrible, because these breakthroughs arrive at a time of intense competition between two powerful countries that really don’t trust one another.

But if Americans and Soviets could build a working arms control infrastructure in the 1970s and 80s, the U.S. and China can build an equivalent for the 21st century. Let’s hope they realize they have no choice before a catastrophe makes it unavoidably obvious.

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How TIME Chose Its 2023 List of Next Generation Leaders

Sam Jacobs is Editor in Chief at TIME where he leads TIME's global newsroom and its journalism across all platforms. Since joining TIME in 2013, Jacobs has held a variety of senior editorial leadership positions. Previously, he was national political correspondent at Reuters, associate editor at Newsweek and staff reporter for The Daily Beast. His writing has appeared in the Boston Globe and New York Observer.

One of my favorite stories from *TIME*'s history goes like this: As 1927 came to an end, the editors seized the chance to correct a serious oversight. They had failed to put Charles Lindbergh on the cover to recognize the 25-year-old's remarkable solo flight over the Atlantic, which he'd completed that May. On what was otherwise a slow news week, they gave themselves a mulligan, and for the first issue of 1928 named Lindbergh "Man of the Year," creating what

became one of the most iconic franchises in journalism—what we know today as TIME Person of the Year.

Lindbergh remained the youngest individual to receive the recognition until 2019, when 16-year-old Greta Thunberg was named Person of the Year. These two milestones remind us that leadership has no age requirement. We've known that to be true since TIME's founding a century ago, by a pair of 20-somethings no less. I suspect that is something our readers believe as well: as I wrote in April, nearly half of you are under the age of 35.

That is why I'm so pleased that over the past nine years we've gotten the chance to introduce you all to an impressive group of extraordinary young people via TIME's Next Generation Leaders list, made possible by our partners at Rolex. "To spend time with these individuals is proof of what is possible and what leadership in its multitude of inspiring forms can look like today," says senior editor Emma Barker, who, with senior editor Dayana Sarkisova, led the latest installment of the project.

On the cover, we feature Florence Pugh, a 27-year-old British actor, whom we meet on the cusp of a breakout year with upcoming roles in two highly anticipated movies: Christopher Nolan's *Oppenheimer* and Denis Villeneuve's *Dune: Part Two.* This is an extraordinary moment for Pugh, a performer who is starting to climb the peaks of her profession. "Despite her youth, she has a drive and assurance," says Villeneuve. "You feel you're working with someone who can absolutely go anywhere and do anything emotionally in the most subtle and precise way. She's a raw diamond."

The Next Generation Leaders list is, as always, a global undertaking, with TIME's reporters and editors scouting what leadership looks like across the planet. In this issue, we spend time with rising stars in places including South Korea, Argentina, and Australia, where Melanie Perkins, a co-founder of tech platform

Canva, recently pledged to give away a significant share of equity in her giant startup company. “It was a really easy decision,” she says. “How can you do the most good you can do with billions of dollars?”

Perkins’ drive to improve the world is shared by Brazil’s Rene Silva, who, as an 11-year-old, persuaded teachers at his school to let him join the student newspaper. That effort set him on a journey to launch a paper of his own, covering an entire favela. Today, Silva leads *Voz das Comunidades*, which is dedicated to telling and promoting stories that are frequently overlooked in his country’s media.

Pugh, Perkins, and Silva join impressive leaders like activist Sage Lenier, who is leading a solutions-focused approach to the climate fight, and Ivorian American chef Roze Traore, whose journey through the restaurant world and exploration of family history has led him to the Ivory Coast, to create healing and community through food. Together, this class joins the more than 175 individuals recognized as TIME Next Generation Leaders since 2014. At a moment when society’s problems can seem insurmountable, it is so inspiring to see these young leaders bring new perspectives and share fresh ideas.

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American Born Chinese Reflects a New Era of Storytelling

Chung is the author of the memoirs A Living Remedy and All You Can Ever Know

After years of printing comics at Kinko's and selling them at conventions and local shops, Gene Luen Yang didn't expect his 2006 graphic novel *American Born Chinese* to get the attention it did. Blending the coming-of-age journey of Jin Wang, the son of Chinese American immigrants, with the adventures of characters from the Chinese epic *Journey to the West*, the best-selling book was a National Book Award finalist and won the American Library Association's Michael L. Printz Award for Excellence in Young Adult Literature. Yet despite its success, a screen adaptation wasn't a goal for the author.

"I don't think there was a lot of interest in shows with Asian American protagonists back then," Yang tells me.

The Margaret Cho–led *All-American Girl* had been canceled in 1995 after one season, and networks had hardly rushed to pursue other shows centering the experiences of Asian Americans. Plus, he had his own doubts: he thought it would be hard to effectively adapt and translate the edgiest of the book's three storylines—in which he has a character called "Chin-Kee" embody various racist anti-Asian stereotypes in an attempt to illustrate how harmful they are—for a TV audience. Then, a few years ago, he met Melvin Mar, a producer whose credits include the ABC sitcom *Fresh Off the Boat*, who in turn introduced him to Kelvin Yu, a producer and writer *(Bob's Burgers)* who also appeared on Aziz Ansari's Netflix series *Master of None*. Yang says Yu understood the challenges of bringing the graphic novel to life onscreen, and also had ideas about how to expand the story and the cast, address the difficult plotline, and make sure the show could resonate with a new generation.

Read More: *The 100 Best Ya Books of All Time:* American Born Chinese

Mar, Yu, and Yang are now among the executive producers on *American Born Chinese*, a new family-friendly series that premieres May 24 on Disney+ and is directed by Lucy Liu and Destin Daniel Cretton *(Shang-Chi and the Legend of the Ten Rings)*. Yu, the showrunner, explains that both the television-production landscape and viewers' expectations have shifted over the years. "When I was growing up, it was a few networks trying to appeal to tens of millions of viewers, but that's not where we are now," he says. "Look at what's popular on streaming—it tends to be things that aren't straight down the middle. People are more willing and able to dive in."

American Born Chinese features what Yu refers to as "an embarrassment of riches of Asian and Asian American talent." Ben Wang, whom Yu jokingly calls "the Asian American Michael J.

Fox" because "you can't help but root for him," stars as teenage everyman and emerging hero Jin Wang. Daniel Wu and Jim Liu portray Sun Wukong, the Monkey King, and his son, Wei-Chen, while Yeo Yann Yann and Chin Han give two of the show's most emotionally resonant performances as Jin's parents Christine and Simon Wang. And there's a mini-reunion of cast members from Best Picture winner *Everything Everywhere All at Once*, as Academy Award winners Michelle Yeoh and Ke Huy Quan and Academy Award nominee Stephanie Hsu lend additional star power. Once "the only Asian face" on sets, Quan tells me it was a joy to collaborate with so many fellow Asians and Asian Americans: "It warmed my heart to see how far we've come."

While the book's three distinct storylines—all focused on individuals grappling with questions of identity and belonging—come together toward the end, the new series allows its many arcs and characters (human and divine) to interact from the beginning. It also brings the story from the '90s into the present and spends more time at home with the Wang family than the book, in which Jin's parents are minor characters. When you turn a self-contained 240-page graphic novel into an eight-episode series, you're going to have to add some material. But far from feeling extraneous, the family scenes are among the funniest and most moving in the show: Christine taking Jin shopping and striking out with every suggestion; Simon realizing that he has let his wife down by giving up on some of their shared dreams; Jin unhappily listening to his parents argue in a language he struggles with from the other side of the wall. Many of the challenges Jin faces, his questions about who he is and where he belongs, are mirrored in his immigrant parents' lives.

Read More: *The Most Influential People of 2023: Ke Huy Quan*

Chin Han points out that in their scenes together, he and Yeo Yann Yann performed "over 90%" of their dialogue in Mandarin, with subtitles: "And the writers trusted it would land, and trusted

the audience to follow the story and the emotional beats." Both said they appreciated the show's portrayal of an Asian American family. "An Asian family is often seen in a particular way, focused on achievement, but my experience of being within an Asian family is much more interesting and varied," says Chin Han. Yeo Yann Yann loved that her character was "trying so hard to understand her son. She's not the typical Tiger Mom we see on some shows."

In the series, there is no cousin "Chin-Kee"; instead, we meet Freddy Wong, a character, played by Quan, on a '90s show within the show. Jin is humiliated when a classmate compares him to the accident-prone Wong, the butt of every joke on the old sitcom. Quan initially turned down the role because he feared it was "exactly the kind of portrayal of Asian characters that we don't want to see in 2023," but changed his mind when he learned more about the character's journey.

"We actually get to meet the actor who played the character later on," Quan says, referring to an episode in which viewers learn what it felt like to always be the punch line, not the hero. "It was us bringing a mirror, showing the audience what it was like being an Asian actor in the '80s and '90s. Those were the kind of roles I was auditioning for, left and right. They were trying to show how representation like this trickles down and affects a regular kid like Jin—what it does to his self-esteem, his sense of identity."

Full of stunts and jokes and mythological figures, anchored by a realistic and heartfelt family story, *American Born Chinese* plunges readers into worlds both like and unlike our own and resists easy categorization. It also doesn't seem to have to grapple with the question of whether a sizable American audience will watch or understand a show about an Asian American family—perhaps because that question has been answered by shows like *Fresh Off the Boat*, which ran for six seasons. "Some previous shows about Asian Americans—and there aren't many, right?—were sort of forced to deal with certain aspects of the experience because

nobody had ever done it before," Wang says. "Ours is one of the first shows about an Asian American experience that feels like it can just have fun."

American Born Chinese is nothing like *Everything Everywhere All at Once*, yet the projects share more than cast members—a sense of playfulness and creative freedom permeates both. Yu says one of the lessons he took from working on *Master of None* is that an audience will respond when creators are "laser-specific" about an experience. *American Born Chinese* is a product of many individuals' experiences—Yu based Jin's parents on his own and the character of Freddy Wong on one of his first acting roles; the set designers took inspiration from their families' homes for the Wangs' house. "If you make something true, something you like, something that makes you laugh—if you do all that, and other people don't like it, you can sleep at night," Yu says. "What you couldn't live with is if you pandered to what you thought an audience wanted."

I was in my 20s when I first encountered *American Born Chinese*. It was only the third or fourth graphic novel I'd read at the time, and I remember being first charmed and then drawn into the imaginative world of the book, though I was outside its target age range and my upbringing as a Korean American adoptee bore little resemblance to Jin's. Asian American characters were scarce in the books I'd read growing up—when I did find us, we were often stereotypes or sidekicks—but I'd always wanted to believe that there was an audience for stories focused on our lives, our families, our histories. I wanted to help write those stories, and I also wanted to read more and more of them. I still do. If it is slightly easier to find them now, it is in part because readers—and viewers—continue to demand more.

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“It’s a privilege to get to elevate so many talented people. It’s a time for us to flex,” Yu tells me. “The door has cracked open, and the responsibility is now ours—what are we going to do with it?”

Yang is gratified to know the comics he once drew and stapled by hand have become a foundation on which others can build their own Asian American stories. Now that his book is a show, the collective work of so many, his creation is “no longer a ‘me’ story,” he says, but “an ‘us’ story.” He hopes viewers will reflect on “whatever part of their lives makes them feel like an outsider, [and] learn to see that as a gift.” It’s a point echoed by Quan: “We all work so hard to find ourselves, our identity, and sometimes we want to be like others. But there’s beauty in being who we are. We all need to give ourselves a little more love.”

Chung is a TIME contributor and the author of A Living Remedy

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What Johnny Depp Has Become

Stephanie Zacharek is the film critic at TIME. She is the recipient of a Newswomen's Club of New York award, and was a 2015 Pulitzer Prize finalist.

The aging process is kind to no one, and that includes Johnny Depp.

On Tuesday, Depp was here in Cannes to walk the red carpet for the festival's opening night film, Maïwenn's misunderstood-mistress extravaganza *Jeanne du Barry*, in which Depp plays King Louis XV, whose devotion to his favorite extramarital squeeze brought scandal upon Versailles. When it was announced that a Depp film would be opening the festival, murmurs of "Sacre bleu!" were heard far beyond the kingdom, though perhaps not so much in France: the festival itself has opened its arms wide to Depp, who hasn't exactly been untouched by controversy in the past few years, given his involvement in two high-profile defamation suits connected with allegations that he physically abused his former wife, Amber Heard. (The jury ruled that Heard defamed Depp on three counts and awarded him $15 million in damages; Depp was

found guilty of one of three charges in Heard's countersuit and she was awarded $2 million in compensatory damages.)

The allegations, and the details of the subsequent messy trials, are horrifying enough by themselves. The trollish Depp fans who took to social media to harass Heard and the women who stood up for her made the situation uglier. You'd have to have been cryogenically frozen through most of 2022 to have missed any of it. Yet at the festival's opening press conference on Monday—this is its 76th edition—Cannes chief Thierry Fremaux defended the festival's choice to kick off with the film. "If there's one person in this world who didn't find the least interest in this very publicized trial, it's me," he said. "I don't care what it's about. I also care about Johnny Depp as an actor."

Fremaux's ostrich-head-in-the-sand act is disingenuous. But his last two statements entwine opposing ideas that bear thinking about. Is it possible to care about acts Depp may have committed, and to care about what happens to women when they come forward with allegations of domestic violence? And also to care about Johnny Depp as an actor—as a performer who, at certain points of his career, if no longer, was capable of bringing us the kind of joy that we go to the movies for in the first place?

Though Depp still has legions of hardcore fans who will not give up the *Black Pearl* for love or money—quite a few of them showed up in Cannes on Tuesday night to cheer him on—many of us who used to love him can't look at him exactly as we did in the 1990s. The Depp of *Donnie Brasco*, of *What's Eating Gilbert Grape*, of *Ed Wood* and *Dead Man*, was magnificent to behold, an actor of microshaded subtlety and unforced charm. Even his roles in the earlier Tim Burton movies—as a somber, stammering Ichabod Crane in *Sleepy Hollow*, or a winsome artificial boy in *Edward Scissorhands*—showed layers of depth within their expressionist stylization. His translucent silent-movie-star skin, his eyes capable of shifting emotional colors within the space of a heartbeat: to

watch him was to sink into the deepest pleasures an actor can give us.

Then Depp began to hide—or allow himself to be hidden—in the bedraggled pirate ruffles and rock-star eyeliner of the dismal *Pirates of the Caribbean* movies, and the "Look at me!" multi-toned pancake of Tim Burton's exhaustingly eccentric characters. His lost-boy naivete began to come off as schtick. In the *Pirates* movies, his googly-eyed mannerisms drove audiences wild. Why bother with acting when gimmickry will do the trick?

According to the current rules of how we're supposed to view male artists accused of unspeakable behavior, it should be easier to despise Depp as a human being now that it's become so hard to defend him as an actor. Righteous anger is the easiest fix for complex, possibly conflicting feelings. Even defending the *artistry* of a great or once-great filmmaker or actor—it could be Roman Polanski, Woody Allen, or Bernardo Bertolucci—who has either committed or been accused of committing a heinous act is enough to get you branded a traitor. Essayist Claire Dederer has just written a whole book about how we should feel about what she calls "monstrous men." It's normal to feel troubled or conflicted about artists we love, or once loved, but we've somehow been conditioned to believe that even conflicted feelings are bad. God forbid we hold two or more ideas in our heads at once.

I no longer have much invested in who the actor Johnny Depp is today, and I have serious doubts about what he must be like as a human being. But watching him both in *Jeanne du Barry* and on the red carpet—and reading the reports coming through this morning about how moved he was to have received such a warm welcome in Cannes—only made me miserable. *Jeanne du Barry* is gleamingly, tastefully handsome, as well as sometimes thunderously dumb, but it's not unwatchable. Maïwenn herself plays the Countess du Barry, though in only a few scenes does she wear the typical 18th century beehive of powdered hair; mostly, her

locks flow anachronistically wild and free, like Stephanie Seymour's in the '90s. She plays Jeanne as the Fun Gal of Versailles—wearing big clown stripes! donning breeches and ruffles and tromping around on horseback! kissing the king behind a napkin at formal dinners! And she "owns" a Black child, given to her by her paramour the king, but don't hold that against her—she's really, really nice to him.

As the ruler who ostensibly adores her, Depp—in some scenes his cheeks and lips monstrously rouged, almost in a garish Edward Scissorhands approximation—merely looks like a guy who has no idea how he landed in Versailles. His lines, delivered in French, have a waxy stiffness. His eyes look beady and glazed, as if all his eyelashes had been burned off. This is Depp's most high-profile film in years, but it's less a comeback than a tepid lurching into a very small spotlight.

The photos and footage of Depp on the red carpet don't make the story any happier. He looked to be pleased by the attention, but there was also something tentative about him, as if he'd lost his grip on this particular reality—the false reality of a crowd's adoration at a place like Cannes—and was very slowly getting it back.

Reclaiming that false reality is likely to do Depp more harm than good. A 2018 *Rolling Stone* profile by Stephen Rodrick, written in the aftermath of the Depp-Heard breakup, showed the actor spending much of his time locked away in a mansion fortress, guzzling expensive wine (reportedly more than $30,000 worth each month), and nursing the depths of his melancholy. Depp is an adult; he's about to turn 60. He has made his own decisions and created his own problems. But I don't think anyone who truly cares about acting and actors should feel happy about what he's become. To see him looking as if all the life has been sucked out of him—not to mention the creeping jowlishness, the deepening frown lines, and other physical indignities that come with getting older—is akin to

watching a bird fall from the sky, though birds, unlike men, don’t bring about their own downfall. Depp is a nest of tragedies, an extraordinarily gifted man who has most likely hurt others, as well as himself. He’s his own worst enemy, and no matter how loudly the crowd cheers for you, there’s no glamour or valor in that.

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Celine Song and Greta Lee on Past Lives' Alchemy of Memoir and Artistry

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Toward the end of the A24 romantic drama *Past Lives*, there comes a scene in which silence speaks louder than words. For 45 long seconds on-screen—written as two minutes in the script—Nora (Greta Lee) and Hae Sung (Teo Yoo) stand, at first facing the street, then gradually, almost imperceptibly, shifting to face each other.

They're waiting for an Uber to arrive to take one of them to the airport. The actors, just like their characters, didn't know when the car was going to come. The director, Celine Song, made a tiny gesture to cue the car when she was ready.

"The way that I could decide when that was, is knowing what those two minutes have to be, which is that it has to feel—just like the movie—like eternity and decades and a person's whole life," Song says between sips of a green smoothie in a coffee shop in Manhattan's East Village. "But also [it has] to feel too short."

Past Lives, which opens in limited release on June 2 before expanding nationwide June 23, is a grown-up love story about, among other things, time and the way it moves. Twice, the words "12 years pass" appear on-screen. That really is how life feels, says Song: Sometimes 12 years flash by in the blink of an eye, other times one minute can feel like a hellish decade, and still other times a magical moment can feel like a welcome eternity.

In the film, which premiered at Sundance to raves, we first meet Nora as a kid (played by Moon Seung-ah), before she changes her name from Na Young to Nora and immigrates with her family from Seoul to Canada—but not before she develops a crush on her friend Hae Sung (Seung Min Yim) at school. Before her family leaves, her mom arranges a chaperoned "date" between Nora and Hae Sung in a Seoul park to help her file away good memories of Korea.

Twelve years later, Nora has immigrated again to New York City, where she is pursuing a bright career as a playwright. Hae Sung, now finishing mandatory military service in South Korea, finds her on Facebook, the two reconnect, and Skype hangouts ensue. But Nora wants to fully commit to her life in New York, so she ends the fledgling relationship and heads to an artist residency in Montauk, where she meets and falls for another writer, this one a white American man, Arthur (John Magaro). Another 12 years later, Nora and Arthur are married, and Hae Sung is coming to visit New York, their first meeting in 20 years.

The movie is a work of autofiction: It follows the broad brushstrokes of Song's own life. At age 12, she too immigrated from Seoul to Canada. She studied theater at Columbia University in New York City, reconnected with her childhood sweetheart over Skype, then met her now-husband, the writer Justin Kuritzkes, at a fellowship retreat (from the Edward F. Albee Foundation) in Montauk. They got married four years later. Two years after that, her childhood sweetheart came to visit New York.

Song clarifies that there is the truth at the heart of the story, and then there are the facts. The director, wearing a navy blue baseball tee with Pink Floyd's *Wish You Were Here* album cover on the front, her bob tucked under a dark green baseball cap, explains that in making her debut film, she was less interested in recreating exact replicas of characters and places, and more invested in the best way to tell the story.

"The main thing that I believe as an artist is that I cannot let other people's limitations of imagination dictate my imagination," Song says. "All I can do is hope that there are people who can meet the movie as alive as I have made it."

One could read a summary of the movie's plot and conclude that it's a story about a lost woman trying to carve out her own identity through her relationships with men. But for Song, and for Lee, it is about a happily married woman who knows what she wants out of life, both personally and professionally. She's ambitious, she's clear, and she's on the cusp of a reunion with someone important from her past.

"What I loved from the jump with this movie was it wasn't in service of any sort of gaze: white gaze, male gaze," Lee says in a video interview from a parked car, greenery behind her. "It was really liberated from the certain systems and infrastructures in place."

"It really is all in service of this universal idea of love," she continues. "Love not as some sort of neat construct, but something that exists on its own."

In separate conversations, both the director and the actor who plays a version of her talked about the concept of faith as integral to the movie. For Song, it was an act of faith to believe that if a story feels true and compelling and important to her, then it will feel the same to the audience. She trusts that this very specific story will read as universal, "because I know that I'm a part of this universe

in a pretty fundamental way." For Lee, the faith came from an approach Song used in the making of the film: she kept the two leading men completely separate until their characters met on-screen to make the meeting feel genuine. Lee felt like she was in two different movies with them, but she had to trust that "that was the essence of the movie that we were after."

Song and Lee speak like they're in conversation with each other even when they're not—which makes sense, given each one's connection to the character of Nora. Unlike Nora, Lee was born in Los Angeles to Korean parents, but she understands the shared experience of having "this part of my identity that, at different points in my life, [has] been—not closed off, but let go—in order to make space for something else."

There's a scene that bookends the film in which Nora, Hae Sung, and Arthur sit at an East Village bar, inspired by the speakeasy Please Don't Tell in Song's real life. Song felt a visceral power sitting in the middle of her husband and her childhood sweetheart, the only reason why both of them were in that bar on that night, the bridge for language between them. Lee portrays that quiet power and self-assurance masterfully, cool and calm in a complicated situation.

Lee's Nora is grounded, and she accepts the Korean concept of *in-yun* in its passivity. Earlier in the movie, Nora explains *in-yun* to

Arthur as providence or fate: “If two strangers walk by each other in the street and their clothes accidentally brush, that means there have been 8,000 layers of *in-yun* between them.”

It’s easy to think about fate or destiny as something you go get, sometimes you run toward, Song says.

“But the truth is, in Eastern philosophy, where *in-yun* comes from, it is something that comes to you, and you cannot stop it,” she says. “It’s something that you have to learn how to accept.”

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Why Microsoft's Satya Nadella Doesn't Think Now Is the Time to Stop on AI

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(To receive weekly emails of conversations with the world's top CEOs and business decisionmakers, click here.)

The last year has been characterized by a rush of new artificial intelligence (AI) programs being released into the world since OpenAI, a lab backed by Microsoft, launched ChatGPT in November 2022. Both Microsoft and Google rolled out products in March that they say will use AI to transform work, and IBM's CEO Arvind Krishna said the company's AI tool will be able to reduce 30 to 50% of repetitive office work.

Since taking the helm at Microsoft in 2014, at a time when its market dominance with traditional software offerings was waning, Satya Nadella has focused on ensuring the company remains relevant. . The company has invested heavily in Azure, its cloud computing platform, and in AI, pouring at least $13 billion in the leading lab OpenAI. Microsoft's share price has risen nearly tenfold since Nadella became CEO, outperforming the S&P 500, which has merely doubled its value over the same time.

Now, Nadella is using those investments to reenergize Microsoft's traditional Office suite of products like Word, Outlook, and Excel, which are now called Microsoft 365. In March, Microsoft launched 'Copilot,' an AI tool that it says will free people from the drudgery of work by helping to draft emails and white papers, transcribe and summarize meetings, and teach people how to make sense of data in Excel. Copilot was initially released to a small group of enterprise customers and Microsoft is now rolling out the system to a larger group of customers.

Given some of the headlines about AI and its potential uses, from virtual companions to fitness coaches, improvements to office software like Microsoft Word might not sound that exciting, but it may be one of the use cases that has the most impact on many of our lives. Nadella says that making the way we work better will help us as to thrive as individuals and as a society.

TIME spoke with Nadella about Microsoft's principles around AI, how the technology could transform work, and what safeguards should look like.

This interview has been condensed and edited for clarity.

You've said that AI is going to unleash a new wave of productivity and remove the drudgery from our daily jobs. What specifically would you say is

going to change in the workplace with the adoption of AI?

AI itself is very much present in our lives. But if anything, it's moving from being autopilot to being a copilot that helps us at our work. You put the human in the center, and then create this tool around them so that it empowers them.

It's not just about productivity, it's actually taking the drudgery away from work. If you think about all of us at work, how much time do we spend in expressing ourselves and creating? This is what gives us real joy. How much time do we spend just coordinating? And so, if we can tilt that balance towards more creativity, I think we will all be better off.

There are some concerns that this would displace jobs. What responsibility does Microsoft have to address these concerns about job displacement? And what's it doing in that field?

One of the things that I'm most excited about is how [AI] democratizes access to new skills. I mean, to give you a concrete example, developers who are using GitHub Copilot are 50-odd percent more productive, staying more in the flow. We have around 100 million professional developers, we think the world probably can get to a billion professional developers. That will be a massive increase in total developers, because the barriers to being a software developer are going to come down. This doesn't mean the great software developers won't remain great software developers but the ability for more people to enter the field will increase.

Is that Microsoft's responsibility, to make sure that people who are displaced can develop these

new skills?

That absolutely is. In some sense, it's even good for our business. Our mission is to empower every person and every organization on the planet to achieve more. So to me that is a great way to create better-paying jobs, more empowering jobs—jobs that give people more meaning.

What's your biggest concern about the adoption of AI going forward?

The one thing that I find very, very good about the way the dialogue is happening: it's not just about tech optimism. It's about thinking about technology and its opportunities, but also the responsibilities of the tech industry and the broader unintended consequences and how we mitigate them long before they become, sort of, out there in society. So that I think is the right way in 2023. To have both those dialogues simultaneously shows a level of I'll call it maturity both in our industry and in our civic society.

That's why even when we think about AI, perhaps the biggest investment we make isn't in responsibly thinking about AI. It's not even just principles in the abstract, but in the engineering process, even the design choices we've started, which is putting humans in the center. It's a design choice.

There's dialogue and then there's regulation. If you're a government, what do you think you would be doing to ensure that there's enough regulation to protect your citizens from AI?

Already, there is. If you think about what Microsoft did, prior to generative AI and all these Copilots—take what Microsoft did with

neural voice. There are no laws yet but we ourselves have put a lot of governance on how and who can use neural voice. I do think there is a place for dialogue, and there is also a place for us to take responsibility as purveyors of this technology before regulation, and then expect that there will be regulation. But at the end of the day, I think we will all be judged by one and one thing alone, which is, do the benefits far outweigh anything that are the societal consequences.

TIME has reported that Microsoft is lobbying against proposals in Europe to regulate general purpose AI. Why is Microsoft getting involved in this argument in particular?

I'm not particularly familiar with that particular comment on what we may or may not be doing In Europe. But the fundamental thing, I think, is, at the end of the day, the European Union and their regulators will do what is best for Europe and we will participate in Europe within the frameworks of the law and regulation. What any regulator or any government or any society should really do is to get that right balance between what are the benefits of this technology, and what are the unintended consequences that they want to mitigate. We will be happy to dialogue on that and make sure that the first happens and the second doesn't happen.

What is the unintended consequence that you would say regulators should be very wary to mitigate?

I mean, here and now for example, take bias, right? One of the key things is to ensure that when you're using these technologies, that by some unintended way, biased outputs are not causing real world harm. We have to think about the provenance of data. What are we

doing to de-bias these models? This is where Microsoft's done a lot of work, whether it's in the pre-training phase, or even after you deploy a model.

Would you agree to any limits on use of AI for military applications?

I think we've always said that we want to make sure that the best technology that Microsoft has is available to the very institutions that protect our freedom.

I'm sure you saw the open letter that called on leading AI labs to stop training in new AI for six months, and in TIME, there's an op-ed calling on labs to shut down AI completely.. What's your response to those calls that maybe we should slow down and put on the brakes a little?

I think there are two sets of things that are important for us to have robust discussions about. The first one is here and now, how are the real world consequences of any AI being deployed?

And then there is a second part—which I think is also worthwhile talking about—is how do we make sure that any intelligence system we create is in control and aligned with human values?

We have to come back with what are practical ways for us to approach the benefits of these solutions and mitigate the unintended consequences. But ultimately it's for the regulators and the governments involved to make these decisions.

What about this idea that perhaps the developers behind AI don't even quite understand the results

that AI is generating? Do you agree with that idea that you don't even know what's going to happen?

I fall in the camp where I think we shouldn't abdicate too soon our own responsibility. It's a most stochastic complex system. There are many stochastic complex systems we deal with. We characterize these stochastic complex systems using lots of other evaluation tests and make sure that they're safely deployed. So it's not the first time we are dealing with complexity in the real world.

What's another example of one such system?

Biology; environment? There's many things that we observe, we try to get empirical results. We try to deal with it in such a way that we really get the benefits of what we're doing. I feel like we are quick to talk about this as the last frontier and the only technology.

I think it's an absolutely amazing set of technologies that are coming. They do show scaling effects. We should be grounded in what is happening, we should be able to characterize them, safely deploy them. All I want us to do as Microsoft is do the hard work. Do the hard work of making sure that the technology and its benefits far outweigh any unintended consequence.

Well, if you think about biology, for example, that's something that exists in the world that we're exploring and trying to understand. Whereas AI is something that we ourselves created, and maybe that's why there's so much fear around it. In that lens that AI is something that we are doing, should we perhaps be a little bit

more cautious than with other systems like biology?

I think about what was the real genesis of the entire computer industry, as Vannevar Bush wrote in As We May Think. The computer industry was about creating tools for the human mind, so that we can do more, understand more of the natural world—whether it's the climate or biology. So, I feel that us creating technologies that allow us as humans to be able to increase our knowledge, do science, help the human condition—is what is the core to enlightenment. And so therefore trying to say, well, "now is the time to stop"—that doesn't seem the right approach.

There does seem to be this urgency to make sure we're using AI to the best of our abilities. What is driving that urgency? Is it shareholders, the research community, is it executives at Microsoft? Who do you think's deciding that it's really urgent to try to use AI to the best of our abilities right now?

The world's economic growth has, in my book, kind of stalled. The last time in fact, the economic growth could be attributed to even information technology—the last time it showed up in productivity stats—was when PCs became ubiquitous in the workplace.

So if we really have a goal that everybody in the world should have economic growth and it should be climate positive, and there should be trust in society around it. We need to build new technology that achieves both those goals. So that's why I think AI is exciting.

That doesn’t mean the unintended consequences of AI are not going to be there—whether it’s labor displacement, or whether it’s safe deployment and bias—so we’ve got to take care of those. But let’s not confuse ourselves that we need new technology to help with the economic growth that we enjoyed in the early parts of the 20th century. What if we can have that type of economic growth? This time around, though, it’s much more even—not just in the West Coast to the United States [but] everywhere in the world—small businesses, large businesses, public sector and private sector. That’s a beautiful world that I aspire towards.

If we’re deciding that we’re embracing economic growth, your argument is we should also decide that we’re embracing AI?

When I think about economic growth, it’s about being able to really go back to the ideals of enlightenment, which is about human wellbeing and thriving. Economic growth is what has helped us have the most number of people in the world enjoy better living standards. And so, to me, that’s the goal and in that context, economic growth plays a role, and in that context, technology plays a role.

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